

Two-day International Conference

on

Empowering Humanities and Social Sciences:

A Discourse on Nation Building and Sustainability

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Book of Abstracts

for the two day International Conference on

Empowering Humanities and Social Sciences:

A Discourse on Nation Building and Sustainability

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Conference Theme

Empowering Humanities and Social Sciences refers to the initiative to more fully incorporate human-centered disciplines—such as sociology, history, and education—into nation-building and sustainability processes. Researchers employ discourse analysis to examine how language and narratives influence national identities, power structures, and environmental policies, thereby contributing to the development of more inclusive and resilient societies.

The themes of the conference are, but not limited to:

- Health Humanities
- Digitalization of Humanities
- Enhancing Social Transformation
- Strengthening Policy and Governance
- Racism and its impact on the world
- Driving Behavioral and Cultural Change
- Fostering Critical Thinking and Reflexivity
- Fostering Interdisciplinary Collaboration
- Promoting Social Equity and Environmental Justice
- Other related topics

Our Plenary Speakers

Prof Sangit K Ragi

Prof. Sangit K. Ragi is a Professor of Political Science at the University of Delhi, where he has taught since 2014. He holds a PhD, MPhil and MA in Political Science from the University of Delhi. His areas of teaching and research include ethnicity, nationalism, Indian political thought and public administration. He previously taught at Maharaja Agrasen College and served as Head of the Department of Political Science from 2021 to 2024. He has published widely on Indian politics and related themes.

Prof Ralph Pite

Professor Ralph Pite is Professor of English at the University of Bristol. He holds an M.A. and Ph.D. from the University of Cambridge. His research interests include ecocriticism, twentieth-century poetry, Romanticism, Robert Frost, Thomas Hardy, Dante, ecology and contemporary poetry, and ideas of place in nineteenth- and twentieth-century writing. His scholarship also explores Anglo-Italian Romantic literature. He has contributed to BBC Radio 4's *Natural Histories* and led the *Romantic Bristol* digital project.

Prof Bindu Puri

Professor Bindu Puri is Professor at the Centre for Philosophy, School of Social Sciences, Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi. She holds a Ph.D. in Philosophy from the University of Delhi, with a dissertation on Gandhi's conception of morality. Her areas of specialization include contemporary Indian philosophy, particularly Gandhi, Tagore, Ambedkar and Sri Aurobindo, as well as social, political and moral philosophy. She has over thirty years of teaching experience and has been a Professor at JNU since 2015.

Prof Girish Nath Jha

Professor Girish Nath Jha is Professor of Computational Linguistics at the School of Sanskrit and Indic Studies, Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi. His academic qualifications include an M.A. and M.Phil. in Linguistics from

JNU, a Ph.D. in Linguistics from JNU, and an M.A. from the University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign. His research interests include Indian-language corpora, Sanskrit and Hindi linguistics, computational lexicography, machine translation, e-learning and language technologies. He served as Chairman of the Commission for Scientific and Technical Terminology, Ministry of Education, from 2022 to 2025.

Prof H Kalpana Rao

Professor H. Kalpana Rao is an academic, literary scholar and critic who served as a Professor and HoD in the Department of English at Pondicherry University. She is the current Editor of the Literary Section of *Muse India.* She has been a Fullbright SUSI Fellow and has been awarded the prestigious Shastri Indo-Canadian Graduate Research Award. Her academic qualifications include a Ph.D. where her doctoral dissertation focused on the construction of feminine identity in short stories of Alice Munro and Shashi Deshpande. Her research interests encompass Canadian Literature, along with women's writing, Indian writing in English, gender studies. Her publications include work on South Asian literature like Silappadikaram, gender, diaspora and writings on Indian perspectives. She has also authored a monograph on comparative literary studies.

Dr Avishek Parui

Dr. Avishek Parui is Associate Professor of English in the Department of Humanities and Social Sciences at the Indian Institute of Technology Madras. He holds a Ph.D. from Durham University and is an Associate Fellow of the UK Higher Education Academy. His research interests include Memory Studies, Modernism, Masculinity Studies, Critical Theory and Medical Humanities. He is associated with the Centre for Memory Studies at IIT Madras and is a founding chairperson of the Indian Network for Memory Studies. His scholarship engages literature, memory, postcolonial studies and interdisciplinary humanities research.

Dr Chloe Romanis

Elizabeth Chloe Romanis is Associate Professor in Biolaw at Durham Law School. She is the Director of Equality, Diversity and Inclusion at the Law School. Chloe has a first class LLB (Hons) Law degree and a distinction LLM in Health Care Ethics and Law both from the University of Manchester. She is a Wellcome Trust fellow and completed her PhD in Bioethics and Medical Jurisprudence at the University of Manchester with no corrections in September 2020. In 2020 Chloe was awarded the University of Manchester Distinguished Achievement Medal for Postgraduate Researcher of the Year (FHUMS) and a Faculty of Humanities Outstanding Teacher Award. In 2021, Chloe was awarded the Durham Law School Equality, Diversity and Inclusion Staff Award.

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Panel 1:
Knowledge and the Project of Nation-Building

Beyond STEM: Humanising India's Knowledge Economy

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India's vision of Viksit Bharat @2047 is increasingly articulated through technological advancement, innovation, and the creation of a globally competitive knowledge economy. Yet within this developmental paradigm, the humanities and liberal arts remain caught in a persistent paradox: the capacities they cultivate, including critical reasoning, communication, ethical judgement, cultural literacy, and social understanding, are widely acknowledged as necessary to a complex knowledge economy, but rarely translated into clearly recognised pathways of research, employment, and professional practice. This paper asks: what forms of human capital does undergraduate humanities education produce, and why do existing institutional structures fail to adequately recognise or translate them? Rather than positioning the humanities against STEM, it challenges a narrow conception of human capital that privileges technical competencies while rendering interpretive, communicative, and socio-cultural capacities secondary. Methodologically, the paper employs qualitative policy and discourse analysis of contemporary Indian frameworks concerning higher education, research, employability, skill development, and knowledge-economy formation. It proposes a Humanities Research-to-Work Fellowship Model connecting disciplinary education with funded student research, field-based inquiry, digital humanities, community engagement, and structured collaborations with industry, public institutions, and civil-society organisations. Rather than instrumentalising humanities education through a generic employability agenda, the model seeks to make its existing intellectual labour more legible across research and professional ecosystems. The paper ultimately argues for a broader conception of human capital in which the humanities are understood not as peripheral beneficiaries of development but as active producers of the critical, cultural, ethical, and social capacities through which development itself can become more inclusive, sustainable, and socially accountable.

Civilizationalism and Nation Building

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Civilization functions primarily as a descriptive concept in history and anthropology and also as a metaconcept in macro-history and philosophy to group multiple distinct cultures across vast spaces and times. The discourse of civilization thereby organizes philosophical debates on human pasts and futures, describing an organic cultural umbrella defined by deep historical roots, shared philosophies, language, and traditions that span thousands of years and often stretch across multiple borders. Nation-building is a deliberate, modern political process of creating a unified state with stable institutions, laws, and a shared civic identity within defined borders. Nations are fixed to specific geographic boundaries and sovereign states. In this context, to be sustainable and pragmatic in the deliberate task of nation-building is to identify the threats to self-preservation of a complex social organization. The pedagogical models within the Humanities have carefully overlooked the challenges to political ecology and national self-image, identity and purpose by the uncritical application of theoretical concepts that purportedly interpret reality towards an ideologically deterministic end. The unexamined dominance of certain alien theoretical dogmas has distorted the conclusions that students may have otherwise arrived at regarding the purpose of a State and its pedagogical method for social benefit. Our effort in this paper is to identify a method which can holistically integrate the current canon into a much broader discourse which is historically and politically holistic enough to present a more balanced and graded picture of the nation-building process within the civilizational paradigm.

Interdisciplinary by Design:
English Studies as a Bridge Between the Sciences and the Social Sciences

Aditya Singh (*imrohitadi16@gmail.com)*
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English Studies is usually seen as a subject about literature, language, and interpretation. This paper argues that this view is too narrow. English Studies is, by its nature, already an interdisciplinary subject ,it connects the sciences, social sciences, and humanities in a way few other subjects can. Literature has always engaged with medicine, law, technology, and the environment, and it makes this specialized knowledge easier for ordinary readers to understand. For example, a novel about climate change can reach people more effectively than a scientific research paper. Illness narratives help readers understand medical experience in human terms. Dystopian and speculative fiction shapes how the public thinks about technology and ethics, often before laws or policies are made. In this way, English Studies does not just borrow ideas from other fields, it explains and humanizes them for a wider audience. This paper uses an interdisciplinary and discourse-based approach to argue that English Studies should be seen as a connecting subject, not an isolated one. It gives students the critical thinking and communication skills needed to engage with scientific, social, and technological questions of today. This is especially relevant for Indian higher education, where interdisciplinary work is encouraged in policy but rarely practiced in classrooms. By presenting English Studies as a connecting discipline rather than a separate one, this paper adds to the ongoing discussion on interdisciplinary collaboration in the humanities, and on the role of literary studies in nation-building.

Reimagining Nation-Building in Badal Sircar's *Evam Indrajit*: Addressing Structural Strain and Emphasing the Role of Humanities in Civic Transformation

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This paper examines Badal Sircar's seminal drama *Evam Indrajit* through a theoretical synthesis of Robert K. Merton's sociological strain theory, Albert Camus's existential absurdity, and Sircar's Third Theatre movement. Situating the text within the discourse of post-independence development, the study analyzes how institutionalized education and employment system may generate severe structural strain and latent dysfunctions, leaving urban youth trapped between uncritical conformity and systemic anomie. By pairing Merton's macro-sociological framework with Camus' lens of existential burnout, the paper shows how individual psychological alienation reflects broader institutional friction. Crucially, the paper evaluates how Sircar's Third Theatre aesthetic, characterised by minimal staging, direct audience engagement, and non-proscenium settings, functions as an active diagnostic medium. By dismantling passive spectatorship, Sircar transforms performance into an interactive space for civic reflection and critical reflexivity. Moving beyond traditional anti-establishment critiques, this research demonstrates how humanistic arts contribute constructively to nation-building and public governance by illuminating human resource friction, fostering mental well-being, and promoting human-centered social transformation.

India–Sri Lanka Relations: History, Buddhism, and Cultural Diplomacy

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The relationship between India and Sri Lanka cannot be measured only in trade figures or diplomatic communiqués. It runs deeper, into a shared civilizational memory stretching back over two thousand years — built through the movement of monks rather than armies, and pilgrimage routes rather than political treaties. Buddhism sits at the centre of this bond. It travelled from Indian soil to the island, carried by Emperor Ashoka's son Mahinda, and found in Sri Lanka a home so enduring that it still shapes the island's identity. This paper examines how that early transmission forged a connection neither colonial rule nor modern political friction has fully severed. Sites like Bodh Gaya, Sarnath, and Anuradhapura remain living spaces of exchange, drawing thousands of pilgrims each year in both directions. We also turn to the present, where this ancient link has been consciously repurposed as a tool of soft power. Buddhist circuit tourism, relic exchanges, joint restoration projects, and cultural diplomacy initiatives have drawn on shared heritage to build goodwill — often succeeding where formal channels have struggled, amid tensions over fishing rights, the Tamil question, and China's growing regional footprint. Our central argument is that cultural and religious ties, though usually treated as secondary to strategic concerns, deserve recognition as diplomacy in their own right. In this case, they have proven more resilient in sustaining goodwill than formal state mechanisms. By combining historical analysis with a reading of contemporary cultural policy, this paper makes a case for taking soft power seriously — not as a supplement to hard diplomacy, but as a subject worthy of study on its own terms.

Panel 2:
Digitalization, Education and Sustainable Social Practice

From Digitisation to Digitalisation:
The Future of Social Work as a Human-Centric Practice in India

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Digitisation and digitalisation are often used interchangeably, yet they describe different transformations. Digitisation converts records and processes into machine-readable inputs. Digitalisation reorganises professional relationships, knowledge, and identity around digital infrastructures. This paper argues that Indian social work has largely pursued the first while assuming the second has followed and that social work has absorbed this difference as unacknowledged labour. Drawing on a qualitative study with frontline practitioners, key informants across NGOs, civil society, CSR settings, and social work students, this paper makes three claims. First, digitised systems reward practice that leaves a trace the system can capture, which quietly redefines competence as documentation rather than relation-building, which is at the core of social work practice. Second, practitioner discretion has not been removed. It has been relocated into the narrow gap between what a case requires and what the digitised format permits. Third, social work students are socialised into these digitised, documentation-based systems before they build the relational knowledge needed to work with individuals and communities, raising a direct question about what professional education now reproduces: competence in the system or competence in the social work practice the system was built to support. The future of a human-centric practice cannot be settled by digitised systems alone. It requires deliberate human discretion about how far digital infrastructure could shape professional relationships. Where digitisation makes practice legible to the state, digitalisation would require the profession to specify which forms of knowledge must remain irreducible to a machine-readable input.

Remembering the Forgotten: Literary Memory and Digital Visibility in Tiffany D. Jackson's *Monday's Not Coming*

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Digital platforms have transformed how stories are remembered, circulated, and forgotten, creating new forms of digital memory while accelerating processes of forgetting. While digital platforms reshape collective memory, contemporary Afro-American literature continues to preserve stories that are often overlooked. Tiffany D. Jackson's *Monday's Not Coming*, for instance, preserves the memory of marginalized lives by drawing attention to stories that society neglects and risks forgetting. Existing scholarship examines the novel through trauma, race, hypervisibility, and institutional neglect; however, comparatively less attention has been given to the relationship between literary memory and contemporary digital memory. Addressing this gap, this paper explores how the novel's representations of remembering, forgetting, and invisibility can be contextualized within debates on digital memory. It examines how Afro-American literature preserves marginalized histories while considering whether digital platforms challenge or reproduce social neglect by determining which stories receive public attention. Drawing on Aleida Assmann's Cultural Memory Theory and Digital Memory Studies, the study adopts a qualitative approach and close reading of *Monday's Not Coming*. The analysis focuses on Monday's disappearance, Claudia's fragmented memories, institutional neglect, and the politics of visibility. While digital platforms can expand the visibility of marginalized stories, their circulation is often shaped by trends, algorithms, and short-lived public attention.The study ultimately highlights the tension between the selective, fluid nature of digitally mediated remembrance and literature's capacity to preserve marginalized memories within contemporary cultures of memory.

Litscape India: Reconceptualising Humanities and Social Sciences Curricula through an AI-Enabled Digital Ecosystem

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Meaningful learning transcends the spatial and epistemic confines of the classroom. Contemporary education seeks to cultivate adaptable, culturally responsive and globally competent graduates who can navigate a knowledge-driven economy. In this context, self-directed learning assumes a critical significance as it mediates between textual knowledge and experiential realities. Despite this, self-directed learning embedded within the socio-cultural realms remain peripheral to the formal curricula of Humanities and Social Sciences. Digital Humanities with its capacity to visualise, spatialise and computationally interpret cultural knowledge presents a methodological possibility to address this gap. The paper intends to introduce Litscape India, an AI-enabled digital observatory that integrates geospatial technology and participatory learning that occurs in public places, heritage sites, transit zones and other informal cultural landscapes. The options in the app namely City as Classroom, Ask Coach, Digital Archiving and Comparative Reading change classroom learning into an interactive and accessible experience for the learners beyond the classroom. The platform also seeks to create the first geo-tagged database for self-directed learning practices and pedagogical innovation in Humanities and Social Sciences. The paper conceptualises Litscape India through two interrelated dimensions: epistemic visibility and behavioural transformation. The former involves spatial identification and digital representation of literary and cultural knowledge thereby challenging the institutionally sanctioned canons of knowledge. The latter revolves around the transformative potential of plural knowledge ecologies that can foster a sense of cultural belongingness among the students. Furthermore, the paper argues that Litscape India can enable a responsible shift in the way learners perceive shared environments thereby ensuring a sustainable future.

Towards a Sustainable World through a Sustainable Campus: An Ecocritical Enquiry into Digital Carbon Footprints

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The digital campus is often imagined as a greener campus: fewer printed pages, fewer physical resources, and greater access through technology. Yet behind every online lecture, cloud-stored file, streamed video, and AI-generated response lies a material infrastructure of servers, data centres, electricity, water, minerals, and electronic waste. The apparent immateriality of the digital therefore conceals an expanding ecological footprint. This paper, "Towards a Sustainable World through a Sustainable Campus: An Ecocritical Enquiry into Digital Carbon Footprints," examines this contradiction through the everyday digital practices of university students and teaching faculties. Drawing on survey data concerning students' digital consumption, AI use, online learning, streaming, cloud storage, and awareness of digital carbon footprints, the study explores the gap between technological dependence and technocivic consciousness. An ecocritical framework, informed by concepts of slow violence, dark ecology, and the materiality of digital media, is used to make visible the environmental relations hidden behind ordinary digital activities. The paper further brings the Vedic concept of Ṛta, understood as a principle of order, harmony, and balance, into dialogue with contemporary digital ecology. Rather than presenting technology as inherently harmful or Ṛta as a ready-made solution, the paper asks a more fundamental question: Can a campus be called sustainable when its digital convenience depends upon ecological costs that remain largely invisible to its users? It argues for a shift from merely digitalising the campus to developing an ecologically conscious digital campus, where technological advancement is understood alongside its environmental responsibilities.

Enhancing Social Transformation Through Inclusive Education, Digital Innovation, and Community Participation: A Framework for Sustainable Development

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Social transformation refers to long-term changes in social structures, institutions, values, and human relationships that improve equality, justice, and quality of life. In the twenty-first century, rapid technological advancement, globalization, climate change, and widening socioeconomic inequalities have created both opportunities and challenges for sustainable social development. This paper examines the role of education, digital technologies, community participation, and public policy in enhancing social transformation. It proposes an integrated framework that combines inclusive education, technological innovation, participatory governance, and sustainable development practices. The paper concludes that collaborative efforts among governments, educational institutions, civil society, and communities are essential for creating resilient and equitable societies.

Panel 3:
Digital Society: Affect, Media and Changing Social Relations

Recontextualising Psychological Terms on Instagram among Gen Z: A Discursive Psychological Analysis

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Psychological terms like anxiety, depression, and trauma are now part of everyday Gen Z communication on Instagram. Users apply them not only to mental health but to relationships, humour, and everyday conflict. Existing research has looked at how psychological language becomes popular, trivialised, or used for self-diagnosis on social media, but less is known about what these terms actually do in everyday online interaction. This study looks at how these three terms are recontextualised in Gen Z Instagram discourse, and how their meanings are negotiated outside strictly mental-health contexts. Using a qualitative approach informed by Discursive Psychology, the study analyses 60 public Instagram posts and captions, along with their comment sections, collected through purposive keyword and hashtag sampling. The sample includes accounts that publicly identify as Gen Z through stated age or contextually evident generational cues. The analysis explores how these terms are used to build identity, explain or justify experiences, negotiate relationships, seek validation, and create humour or solidarity. The study aims to examine how clinical language is repurposed as a social resource for identity and relationships, contributing to broader conversations about self-diagnosis and mental health literacy in digital spaces.

Caring Through the Screen: A Care-Ethical Reading of Digital Relationships in Nisha Susan's *The Women Who Forgot to Invent Facebook and Other Stories*

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Contemporary digital existence has transformed the ways in which intimacy, trust, and accountability are seen. Social media networks, online dating platforms, health software, and anonymous digital communities now facilitate interactions that were previously performed in-person, raising questions regarding the definition of care in the context of screens, algorithms, and remote audiences. *The Women Who Forgot to Invent Facebook and Other Stories* (2020) by Nisha Susan is a short-story collection. The research focuses on three fictional stories from the collection - "The Gentle Reader", "How Andrew Wylie Broke My Heart", and "Mindful". Each fiction exemplifies a unique form of digitally facilitated interaction: a writer's engagement with an online audience that transitions from recognition to harassment; a narrator's involvement in an online dating platform and the fabricated identities that emerge within; and a user's connection with a customised meditation app that seemingly responds to her emotional experiences. The theoretical framework is Joan C. Tronto's ethics of care. The research aims to achieve three objectives. Firstly, it utilises Tronto's care ethics framework to analyse the three narratives and assess what it reveals about the representation of care in digitally mediated life. Secondly, it analyses how Susan's wry and self-reflective narrators employ irony to reveal the disparity between performed care and actual care. Thirdly, it contrasts the portrayal of digital relationships in each of the three narratives, along with the dynamics of care, trust, and responsibility that arise within them. The study connects literary depiction to feminist care ethics, offering a framework for understanding how literature mirrors the ethical complexities of digital life. This approach expands care ethics from individual relationships to encompass the public, intimate, and algorithmic connections that characterise contemporary life, while also demonstrating the lasting importance of literary analysis in conversations about care, technology, and social interactions.

War/Sports and Peace: Media, Rivalry, and Fan Culture in Indian Television Advertisements

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Numerous studies have been conducted over the years that view sports as a powerful medium for creating peace, harmony, and fraternity; a space where national rivalries can be softened and bridges built through mutual interactions and cultural exchanges. However, the conceptu-alization of sports as a peace-building arena, offering counter-balance to political turmoil and geopolitical tensions across the national boundaries, has often been questioned, particularly after the publication of George Orwell's essay "The Sporting Spirit" (1945) which famously claims that sports is equivalent to "war minus the shooting". From an Orwellian perspective, the sports field, instead of being a site that restores peace or harmony, emerges as a symbolic, modern-day battle-field, and sport as a mimicry of warfare, marked by nationalist emotions. It amplifies rivalries and antagonism among countries, rather than alleviating them. Drawing upon Orwell's insights, the aim of this study is to examine how media, spectators, and mediated fan-culture shape the contemporary cricketing narratives in South Asia, particularly the cricketing histories shared by India and Pakistan. Through an analysis of the popular Mauka-Mauka television advertisement series, the study argues that the mediatized and spectator-oriented narratives surrounding the cricket encounters between India and Pakistan, occasionally frame these matches as a symbolic warfare. The paper also expands Orwell's argument by illustrating that these media advertisements do not completely dissolve the narratives of antagonism and symbolic rivalry, but use humor, wit, and laughter to actually repackage and soften them.

The Threshold Problem: How the Definition of "Excessive Gaming" Shapes Its Measured Impact on Self-Esteem, Aggression, and Sleep

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Aggression, poor sleep and low self-esteem are all regularly linked to excessive online gaming. However, the term "excessive" is not impartial. The DSM-5 classifies Internet Gaming Disorder as a condition for additional research, whereas ICD-11 added gaming disorder as a disorder owing to addictive behaviours. The two frameworks produce remarkably divergent prevalence estimates, with DSM-5 criteria finding about twice as many instances as ICD-11. Researchers' measurements and findings are influenced by the label's clinical, moral and cultural presumptions. To examine the impact of excessive internet gaming on self-esteem, aggression and sleep, while critically reflecting on how "excessive gaming" is defined and pathologized in the research literature. This research uses a two-arm mixed-methods design. Using validated measures of self-esteem, aggression, sleep quality, gaming hours and gaming disorder screening, the empirical arm polls gamers. The critical arm conducts a threshold experiment in which the same dataset is re-analyzed under competing published definitions of excessive gaming (hour-based cutoffs, DSM-5 and ICD-11 criteria), and the operationalisation of "excessive" in the literature is investigated through discourse analysis, researcher positionality and gamer narratives. The threshold experiment investigates the possibility that some of the measured impact is a definition artefact. While still producing empirical results, the study shows that "excessive gaming" is created rather than discovered if effect sizes change with the threshold. The study makes a methodological case for reflexivity and threshold transparency in digital mental health research.

Reading the Receipt:
Digital Advertising as Text in the Discourse of the Pink Tax

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Advertisements, though rarely acknowledged as traditional sites of literature, function as compressed narrative and rhetorical texts that possess diction, symbolism, implied narrators, and persuasive arcs that are heavily comparable to canonical literary forms. This study thus foregrounds advertising copy— particularly within the digital marketplace— as a site of literary and discourse analysis thereby examining how the "pink tax", that is, the practice of pricing products higher than their functionally identical counterparts, is discursively manufactured through language employed in "femvertisements", instead of being rooted in their material composition. Drawing on Judith Williamson's ideas on the semiotics of advertising, Erving Goffman's work on gender display, and Ruchi Jaggi's discourse analysis, this study attempts a close-reading of digital advertising campaigns for gendered consumer goods (razors, personal care products, and services) to reveal how adjectival choice, color symbolism, and narrative framing construct femininity as a premium and purchasable identity. The study argues that this discourse forms ground for identity-building work extending beyond the marketed object itself. It is language that manufactures artificial gendered "need" and simultaneously naturalizes gender difference as a lived social category, permeating consumption patterns, perception of the self, and overall identity. Situating this within the concern for sustainability, the paper further deconstructs how gendered product duplication into separate "his and hers" versions lead to unnecessary production, packaging, and waste, positioning gendered advertising discourse as materially anti-sustainable. By reading ad copy as literature, the study discusses the prevalent discourses and demonstrates that reforming these discourses is central to imagining more equitable and sustainable futures. Furthermore, this study advocates for expanded literary attention to digital, commercial texts, arguing that discourse analysis of advertising can reveal popular power dynamics, deconstruct naturalized assumptions about gender and consumption, and promote transformative, sustainable narratives of identity in both material and human terms.

Panel 4:
Legibility and Power: Institutions, Bodies and Marginalized Lives

Ear-Marked: Registration, Legibility, and the Paper Animal in Perumal Murugan's *Poonachi*

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Perumal Murugan's *Poonachi, or the Story of a Black Goat* (2016; English translation 2018) has been read largely within animal studies and as an allegory of authoritarian control. This paper proposes a narrower reading: that documentation constitutes one of the novel's crucial technologies of governance, and that its bureaucratic power operates through the inscription of life into administrative categories. Poonachi must be produced before the state, counted, and ear-pierced before she can be lawfully kept; the mutilation is therefore also an act of inscription, converting a living animal into a record. Drawing on James C. Scott's account of state legibility, and moving beyond readings that primarily understand the novel through the vocabulary of bare life, the paper argues that Poonachi dramatizes the moment at which a living being is displaced by its file. Three scenes anchor the analysis: the queue at the registration office, where waiting itself performs the state's authority; the ear-piercing, where identification is achieved through wounding; and the drought sequence, where the registered animal becomes an accounting problem before it becomes a dying one. The paper further contends that the fable form is not ornamental but methodological: allegory enables Murugan to represent a documentary regime without naming a specific jurisdiction, making its logic portable across political contexts. Registration thus emerges not as a neutral administrative procedure but as a minor technology of nation-building, through which life is rendered countable, classifiable, and governable. Situating the novel briefly alongside contemporary practices of biometric identification and livestock tagging, the paper concludes that literary attention to the paperwork of governance offers the humanities a precise analytic for understanding how administrative systems transform living subjects into legible objects of power.

From Care to Control: Lucia State Hospital as a site of power in *Ratched* (2020)

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The Netflix series *Ratched* (2020), a prequel to *One Flew Over the Cuckoo's Nest*, is examined in this paper as a dramatised portrayal of a mid-twentieth century psychiatric institution. The series brings to light Lucia State Hospital as a site of power through characters like nurse Ratched and Dr. Hanover. A Foucauldian reading of the series exposes the asylum as a panoptic structure, characterised by constant surveillance and control. The long linear corridors, open wards and strategically positioned nurses' station ensures that patients are constantly monitored. This internalises surveillance and patients begin to regulate their own behaviour in anticipation of observation. The visual grammar of the series demonstrates how power is exercised through psychotherapeutic procedures like hydrotherapy, ice prick lobotomy and the use of straitjackets and various other restraints. Equally significant is the show's engagement with sexuality, particularly its depiction of homosexuality being pathologised as mental illness. This paper contends that the series shows how mental illness is constructed and performed. It takes into account Foucault's notion of "medical gaze", where patients are reduced from a person to a body which is managed, categorised and later discarded by epistemic authority. It asserts that the body is a primary site where power is inscribed and the psychiatric institution as producing disciplined bodies, thereby blurring the boundary between care and coercion.

Illegible Bodies: State Legibility and Narrative Resistance in J.M. Coetzee's *Life & Times of Michael K*

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Modern nation-building relies on the state's ability to classify, document, and render its citizens legible within administrative and ideological frameworks. This article argues that J.M. Coetzee's *Life & Times of Michael K* exposes the ethical and political limits of this project by presenting a protagonist who resists incorporation into state narratives. Michael K's silence, physical vulnerability, and refusal to conform to institutional expectations frustrate the bureaucratic, medical, and military systems that seek to identify, diagnose, and govern him. The study scrutinizes how the novel exposes the violence inherent in compulsory legibility, grounding Michel Foucault's concept of power/knowledge, Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's critique of subaltern representation, and G. Thomas Couser's work on narrative ethics. It contends that Michael K's near-mutism is not a sign of absence or deficiency but an ethical mode of resistance that unsettles the state's claim to epistemic authority over marginalized bodies. Coetzee, by shadowing psychological transparency and narrative closure, debunks institutional claims to interpret and represent vulnerable subjects. The study argues that Life & Times of Michael K advances an ethics of unreadability that critiques dominant models of citizenship, governance, and identity formation. It contributes a significant literary intervention into contemporary debates on state power, disability, social justice, and the politics of representation.

Imagining Sustainable Governance: Gender Performativity and Necropolitics in Sheri S. Tepper's *The Gate to Women's Country*

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Sheri S Tepper's *The Gate to Women's Country* has always been interpreted as a feminist utopia. Existing scholarship has examined the novel from feminist, ecofeminist, and post-apocalyptic perspective. However, the intersection of gender performativity and necropolitical governance has received relatively little attention. This paper bridges the gap by exploring Tepper's concept of gender as performance practice that functions as a mechanism through which sovereign power regulates life, death, and social order. It employs a qualitative methodology grounded in close textual analysis. By integrating Judith Butler's theory of gender performativity with Achille Mbembe's concept of necropolitics, this analysis demonstrates that Necropolitical performances and they regulate identity reproduction and social behaviour. The Councilwomen's control over both warfare and reproduction establishes a necropolitical order that makes the warrior masculinity expendable. This article argues that Tepper's critique goes beyond patriarchal domination. *The Gate to Women's Country* represents gender performativity as a technology of necropolitical governance. It demonstrates that reversing patriarchal authority does not dismantle hierarchical power, rather it reproduces new forms of sovereign control. Necropolitical governance first constructs gender identities through institutional practices and then mobilises those identities to regulate survival, reproduction, and disposability.

From Marginalization to Citizenship: Transgender Identities and Social Transformation in Contemporary India

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Transgender identities in India have historically been shaped by intersecting structures of heteronormativity, gender binarism, social stigma, and institutional exclusion. In contemporary India, legislative and policy interventions have increasingly recognized transgender persons as rights-bearing citizens; however, formal recognition does not necessarily translate into substantive citizenship, social acceptance, or a meaningful sense of belonging. This paper examines transgender citizenship as a lived and negotiated process, exploring the relationship between identity, recognition, belonging, and social transformation. Drawing on qualitative empirical insights from transgender communities in Uttarakhand as a regional context, the study investigates how individuals negotiate their identities and participation within familial, social, economic, and institutional spaces. The analysis engages with the theoretical perspectives of recognition, intersectionality, and lived citizenship to examine how normative constructions of gender shape access to dignity, resources, social relationships, and public participation. At the same time, it foregrounds the agency through which transgender individuals challenge, negotiate, and reconstruct exclusionary structures. The paper argues that the movement from marginalization to citizenship cannot be understood solely through legal recognition; it requires transformation in the social and institutional conditions through which citizenship is experienced and enacted. By situating transgender lived experiences within broader debates on social equity, nation-building, and inclusive development, the paper underscores the need to move beyond formal inclusion towards substantive belonging and meaningful participation in contemporary Indian society.

Panel 5:
Reimagining Space and Sustainability: Literature, Ecology, and Social Worlds in South Asia

Beyond the Planned City: Literature, Lived Space, and Sustainable Urban Futures in South Asia

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This paper aims to look at contemporary urban space through spatio-literary lens in South Asian fiction. It is an approach to study literary geography beyond its planned infrastructure. It looks at the production of space through its inhabitants as indicated in the theories of Henry Lefebvre, Michel de Certeau, and other spatial theorists. This paper particularly focuses on South Asian cities as they confront rapid urbanization, climate vulnerability, infrastructural stress, and urban injustice in the twenty-first Century. It points towards a need for a multidisciplinary study of these cities that emphasizes on lived aspects. Bringing together spatial literary studies, urban humanities, mobility studies, and sustainable development discourse, the paper proposes an interdisciplinary methodology for reading literary texts as forms of situated urban knowledge. The paper further considers how such literary insights can complement urban policies by encouraging participatory, culturally sensitive, and people-centred approaches to planning and development. Through literary representations of cities such as Delhi, Mumbai, Karachi, and Kathmandu, the study examines how narratives illuminate everyday problems often obscured by quantitative urban data. Rather than treating the literary city as merely a fictional setting, this study positions literature as a critical tool for imagining more equitable and sustainable urban futures. It ultimately argues that engaging literary representations within urban policy discourse can help bridge the gap between planned cities and lived cities, making sustainability a social, cultural, and human concern alongside an infrastructural one.

Imagining Sustainable Futures through Women's Action-Oriented Climate Praxis: A Global South Voice in Sonali Prasad's *Glass Bottom*

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Climate Change is a multifaceted global challenge across the world. The consequences are affecting the regions and more importantly from affecting the planetary degradation to ecological crisis, it has become a crisis of justice, knowledge, representation, and power. Climate change is now a socio-cultural economic and political crisis. Moreover, climate change consequences are distributed and experienced unevenly across societies across other parts of the world. In *Glass Bottom* (2024) Sonali Prasad has highlighted the how women and marginalized communities are getting affected especially from Global South region. However, representing women as vulnerable subjects of climate change can stimulate biased perspectives and inequalities that climate-justice scholarship seeks to challenge. In this context, understanding, we see women across the Global South are not merely experiencing climate change; they are responding to it, organizing around it, producing ecological knowledge, sustaining communities, transforming livelihoods, and imagining alternative futures. This is manifested in the Sonali Prasad's *Glass Bottom*, through literary intervention as an Indian women climate writing. This study questions how are women affected by climate change to how women are actively imagining, negotiating, and creating sustainable futures in a changing climate. Existing scholarships have established that climate change has gendered consequences. Yet a significant gap remains between recognizing women's vulnerability and understanding women as active agents of climate transformation and future-making. In this study, I position *Glass Bottom* (2024) to examine women's action-oriented climate praxis positioning as a significant site from which alternative sustainable futures can be understood. Through the lens of Critical ecofeminism, Sustainable humanities as an interdisciplinary approach within the Global South Perspectives, the paper discusses how women in Global South would voice, negotiate, and actively participate in reimagining climate futures in the age of climate change.

Therefore, rather than representing women primarily as victims of environmental crisis, the research positions them as knowledge producers and change makers to transformations for better world. Ultimately, the study argues that imagining sustainable futures need women's voices from the margins of climate discourse to the center of decisions about whose futures are protected, whose knowledge counts, and what sustainability should mean.

Preserving the Season: Revaluing Local Food Knowledge in Jharkhand and Uttarakhand for Sustainable Futures

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Today, sustainability is talked about in terms of new technologies, policies and modern solutions. In India, however, there are many such communities who have been practising wise utilization of local resources and adaptation to seasonal variations for a long time. As lifestyles change, with it, food habits and patterns of consumption, some of which might be forgotten. This leads to one pertinent question: why are sustainable practices in local communities not better considered and provided in the current food systems? Seasonal food production methods like sun drying and pickling demonstrate the indigenous methods adopted by local communities in Jharkhand for coping with food scarcity during certain seasons. The use of *sal* leaves to make *pattal* and *dona* for serving food further reflects a close relationship among food, local resources and everyday life. Similarly, the knowledge of food has evolved to suit the seasonal conditions of mountain communities through practices such as *lafhoo* (drying for later use) of radish for future use. The integration of Jharkhand and Uttarakhand provides an opportunity to analyse similarities and differences in the impact of varied landforms on eating habits, as well as common fears of food preservation, resource utilisation and continuity of local knowledge. This paper examines these food practices as local knowledge conditioned by ecology, the seasonality and daily requirements reflecting upon how sustainability can come from the recognition, strengthening and adaptation of knowledge built over many generations, through a comparative reading of Jharkhand and Uttarakhand, not just new technology.

The Nation Beneath the Soil: Extractive Nation Building and Ecological Belonging in Amitav Ghosh's *The Nutmeg's Curse*

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The idea of nation-building is frequently attributed to political sovereignty, economic growth, territorial consolidation, and prospects for the future. However, not all the events contributing to this concept are positive. They include various activities related to the history of plunder and the life and work of ordinary people. Amitav Ghosh, in his book *The Nutmeg's Curse: Parables for a Planet in Crisis* (2021), describes the impact of imperialism and colonial exploitation on nature and ordinary folk. This paper aims to demonstrate how the author relates current developments with their colonial preconditions, changing the then-presented perception of the concept of extractive nation-building. Consequently, this paper will examine the author's thesis about colonialism's unfairness towards nature and local inhabitants through the lens of modern colonialism's growth and development. Firstly, Ghosh begins the discussion by introducing the objective history of the plunder of products and resources connected with the nutmeg. In his account, one can notice an attempt to document all the stages of resource exploitation, starting from the conquest of the island by the Portuguese and ending with the author's observations of today's nature. This approach allows the readers to look at the processes from a micro perspective and see the long-term consequences of colonial exploitation. Furthermore, the problem presented in the book is approached not only from the historical and geopolitical point of view but also from the ecological one. The author tries to describe the importance of nature for the survival and development of nations and states. In this regard, Ghosh introduces the concept of "ecological belonging" that implies the relationship between people and their country. However, the ecological approach goes beyond just belonging to a state; it covers all components of nature that people encounter in their lives. Therefore, the author concludes by saying that for the sustainability of nations, it is essential to rethink the current processes of colonialism and extractivism. In conclusion, this paper would illustrate the main theses and arguments of Amitav Ghosh's *The Nutmeg's Curse: Parables for a Planet in Crisis* (2021). The book provides readers with an opportunity to view history from the

perspective of ordinary people and nature. The author combines the narration of past and modern events to outline the relationship between humanity and the environment. In his search for the essence of nation-building, Ghosh presents an idea that can be called "ecological belonging." Moreover, the author offers a solution to the existing environmental problems, drawing attention to the necessity of changing the current trajectory of development.

Friendship Across Social Boundaries: Gendered Spatial Practices of Secularism in Neelum Saran Gour's *Invisible Ink* and Arundhati Roy's *The God of Small Things*

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The paper presents a comparative feminist geographical analysis of *Invisible Ink* by Neelum Saran Gour and *The God of Small Things* by Arundhati Roy. It emphasizes how female friendships in childhood that go beyond religious boundaries develop into spatial conduct that redefine everyday discriminatory geographies. This study explores how ordinary activities in Allahabad and Ayemenem, like visiting neighbors, sharing domestic courtyards, walking to shrines, and crossing rivers, turn into politically relevant movements. The theoretical framework for the study includes Intersectionality by Kimberlé Crenshaw, Orientation and Affect by Sara Ahmed, and Doreen Massey's concept of relational space. *Invisible Ink* portrays the Allahabad riverscape as a living kshetra wherein women and children interact on a daily basis, despite religious differences. *The God of Small Things* establishes a child-centered, cross-caste relationship that questions the Love Laws and untouchability. Research on Roy discusses caste violence and postcolonial nationhood, and research on Gour focuses on Allahabad's cultural geography, but neither of them addresses friendship as a subversive spatializing practice. The paper argues that both authors depict spaces such as household terraces, shrines, riverbanks, and temporary shelters where gendered and child connections diminish communal boundaries. But the paper also examines how these spaces become brittle and collapse under the pressure from state violence, religious authority, and family. This research highlights that friendship in these novels is emotional and spatializing, contributing to feminist literary studies, spatial humanities, and secularism studies.

Panel 6:
Race, Gender and the Politics of Marginalized Identities

Affect, Power, and the Self/Other Divide: Reading Race, Gender, and National Belonging in Rahul Varma's *Counter Offence*

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Nation-building discourse is not only shaped by policy and governance but by the affective and narrative structures through which "self" and "other" are drawn — determining who counts as belonging within the national fabric. Power itself has conventionally been theorised through this self/other binary, a structure recurring across discourses of gender and race. This study examines how affect mobilises and holds power within these domains, using Indo-Canadian playwright Rahul Varma's *Counter Offence* as a case text, and asks how discourse around national belonging shifts when race and gender converge within a single dramatic frame rather than operating as separate axes. Grounded in affect theory (Ahmed, Massumi) alongside feminist and critical race perspectives on intersectionality (Crenshaw), the study treats affect as a social force that actively constitutes, rather than merely reflects, power relations, national identity, and the self/other boundary within diasporic space. Methodologically, the study uses qualitative discourse analysis of dialogue, stage action, and character positioning to identify moments where affect (fear, shame, anger, desire) constructs or contests racial, gendered, and national belonging. The paper argues that staging race and gender together destabilises singular narratives of national identity, offering diasporic drama as a critical site for rethinking inclusive nation-building.

Becoming Whole: Cultural Heritage and the Reimagined Female Bildungsroman in *Beloved* and *The Color Purple*

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Questions of identity and cultural belonging have been central to Afro-American literature in relation to the Western literary canon for centuries. Still, comparatively little study has focused on the historiography of Afro-American women's identity as expressed through the female Bildungsroman and its interaction with cultural heritage. In response, the present study examines the depiction of Afro-American female selfhood in some selected works of Toni Morrison and Alice Walker through a qualitative, text-based analysis with the primary theoretical framework being Black feminist theory. The study claims that authors both decenter the Bildungsroman, a literary genre traditionally defined as the individual's "process of personal growth toward the integration of society," and instead depict identity formation as a culture-laden collective process and a cyclical one. Their chosen text do not trace the trajectory of an individual's assimilationist progress, but instead suggest ways that selfhood is embedded in female familial bonds, genealogical histories, and collective narratives, making cultural heritage a place of pain and a place of repair. In the process of their protagonists confronting racial discrimination, patriarchal and sexual violence, cultural displacement, contested body autonomy and psychological trauma, Morrison and Walker bring cultural memory, female consciousness and communal solidarity to the fore in the Bildung of Black female subjectivity. The study also argues that this reconfiguration is a conscious formal intervention; it is a formal strategy that challenges the view that Black female development can be captured by developmental models that have been created from a white, male literary tradition because selfhood, in such texts, is not a result of overcoming the circumstances but instead a work of reclaiming silenced histories and shared collectivises. In foregrounding the intersection of race, class, gender, sexuality, and cultural belonging as constitutive, rather than incidental, to identity formation, this study builds upon the current scholarship in a comparative, genre-focused reading of Morrison and Walker, and places the female Bildungsroman in the category of theoretical and political resistance, moving beyond current understandings of Black feminist literary historiography.

Memory, Silence and Marginalized Histories: Reconstructing the Past in Susan Choi's Fiction

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Dominant historical narratives often privilege officially sanctioned accounts of the past while marginalizing personal, familial, and culturally displaced memories. This creates a significant problem for the representation of histories shaped by war, migration, displacement, and cultural conflict, where experiences that do not conform to established narratives may remain silenced or fragmented. Contemporary memory studies challenge the notion of memory as a stable repository of the past and instead understands it as a socially and culturally mediated process through which individuals and communities reconstruct, negotiate, and sometimes contest historical experience. Against this backdrop, this study examines the relationship between memory, silence, identity, and marginalized histories in selected novels of Korean American writer Susan Choi, with particular attention to *The Foreign Student* (1998), *American Woman* (2003), *Trust Exercise* (2019), and *Flashlight* (2025). Drawing primarily on Maurice Halbwachs's concept of collective memory and Paul Ricoeur's theorization of memory, history, and forgetting, the study investigates how Choi's fiction questions dominant versions of the past by foregrounding fragmented recollections, familial silences, cultural displacement, and marginalized experiences. Her narratives reveal that historical consciousness is shaped not only by official accounts but also by personal memories, inherited recollections, and experiences excluded from dominant representations of history. This study examines silence as an active narrative and cultural space through which suppressed histories, unresolved identities, and contested memories become visible. Choi's representations of Korean War memory, diasporic experience, racial identity, and cultural belonging illuminate the tensions between official histories and individual testimonies. By bringing literary memory studies into dialogue with questions of historical representation, the study argues that remembering and forgetting are closely connected to structures of power, inclusion, and exclusion. Choi's fiction consequently demonstrates the capacity of literature to recover marginalized perspectives, challenge established historical narratives and contribute to a more complex understanding of cultural memory and identity. The study thus positions memory as a significant humanities-based framework for examining how the past is reconstructed, contested, and transmitted across individuals and generations.

The Voice Behind the Stone: Re-Examining Virtue, Victimhood, and Social Justice in *Ahalya's Awakening*

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Kavita Kane's *Ahalya's Awakening* gives the famous Ahalya myth a new spin, showing her not as a sinful woman who deserves punishment but as a complex human trying to reclaim her identity, dignity, and power to choose right from wrong. This study explores how Kane overturns old male-dominated views of goodness, victimhood, and women's guilt by allowing Ahalya to share her inner thoughts and make moral judgments for herself. This research paper examines how Kavita Kané's novel *Ahalya's Awakening* describes traditional mythological narratives. This research conducts the discussion within the analytical framework of feminist revisionism and specifically explores two core parts of the novel. One part is the novel's reshaping of the definition of virtue, which discards the unreasonable code of conduct imposed on women in old eras; the other part is sorting out the resistance to the patriarchal structure in the story, which dismantles the inherent setting that men hold all power. Kané's *Ahalya's Awakening* is a powerful intervention into Indian mythology. The Ahalya in the traditional tales circulated in the past was merely a character who passively endured everything: her husband misunderstood her infidelity, did not give her any chance to defend herself, and directly cast a curse to turn her into an inanimate stone. In the end, Kane's new version of the myth shows how old stories can be used to question modern issues like sexism, fairness, and how women are portrayed.

Essential for whom? Class, Charity and Unequal Survival in Udayan Mukherjee‘s “Essential Items”

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This paper examines how Udayan Mukherjee's "Essential Items" (2020) challenges the assumption that the COVID-19 lockdown was a common experience of confinement, arguing that protection and essentiality are class-dependent categories: what counts as an essential good is decided by whoever holds the resources, mobility and social authority to name it. To demonstrate this, the paper offers a close reading of the story's domestic space, material objects, labour and charity, contrasting Silver Crest Apartments with the pavement outside its gate, where the gate functions as a controlled threshold that protects affluent residents while transferring physical exposure to volunteers, security guards, domestic workers and delivery workers, and where the circulation of medicines, groceries, toffees and orange-blossom cake reveals that "essential" means comfort, preference and consumer choice for economically secure residents but immediate nourishment and survival for Malti and her children, while the cake's movement among Meera, Priti and Malti's family distinguishes surplus giving, spontaneous sharing and maternal self-denium within charitable exchanges that provide temporary assistance without redistributing security, agency or social recognition. The paper matters because it establishes the distinction between relief and equality, showing that relief merely transfers goods across an existing boundary while equality would require examining why one group controls resources and protection and another must wait outside to receive them; by locating class hierarchy in ordinary spaces and everyday encounters, Mukherjee's story demonstrates how literature can make marginalized experiences visible and contributes to discussions of social equity and social transformation.

Panel 7:
Gendered Bodies: Care, Motherhood and Biopolitical Power

Emotional Precarity and Commodification: The Impact of Heteronormative Beauty Norms on Breast Cancer Survivors Facing Chemotherapy-Induced Alopecia

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Breast cancer is a major global public health issue and the most frequently occurring cancer in females. The survivors face physical, emotional, and psychological changes along with anxiety and psychological vulnerability. Specifically, hair loss, a side effect that is medically termed Chemotherapy-Induced Alopecia (CIA), contributes to emotional precarity. It also compels them to question their existence and femininity. Qualitative and quantitative studies have shown, and breast cancer survivors have validated in their autobiographies, the same plight and societal shaming. In addition to that, heteronormative and stringent beauty prescriptions oblige them to surrender to the prosthetic industry to sustain normalcy. Subjective positivity and coping strategies are being concealed in medical paternalism, which is sometimes also influenced by conventional aesthetic stigma and flawed by inductive generalisation. Consequently, a multi-billion-dollar cosmetic industry is blooming on their emotional vulnerability and commodifying their urge to fit in society to avoid the societal gaze. This paper aims to investigate how indoctrinated heteronormative and prescriptive beauty norms contribute to the emotional precarity of a breast cancer survivor, undermining their self-esteem and pushing them towards alternative masking and prosthetics that are systematically institutionalised by social norms and eventually supported by the health industry too. Ultimately, this cycle fuels a cosmetic industry that commodifies survivors' vulnerability, transforming emotional distress into a market for institutionalised aesthetic recovery.

From Independence to Interdependence: Gender, Illness, and Care in *Queen of Tears*

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Health Humanities provides a critical space for examining illness not merely as a biomedical condition but as a deeply human experience shaped by identity, relationships, culture, emotions, and social structures. Popular cultural narratives, particularly contemporary Korean dramas, increasingly engage with illness, vulnerability, caregiving, and emotional well-being, thereby contributing to broader understandings of health, relationships, and human experience. Against this backdrop, this paper proposes to examine the Korean drama *Queen of Tears* (2024) through the intersecting lenses of gender, illness, care, and agency. It focuses primarily on Hong Hae-in, whose diagnosis of a life-threatening illness disrupts the structures of independence, authority, and emotional control that define her identity and her marital relationship with Baek Hyun-woo. The paper will explore how illness transforms the relationship between Hae-in and Hyun-woo, gradually shifting their dynamic from emotional distance, conflict, and unequal power relations towards vulnerability, mutual dependence, and care. It will argue that *Queen of Tears* challenges conventional notions of independence by presenting interdependence not as a sign of weakness or loss of agency, but as an essential dimension of human strength, intimacy, and resilience. Through a close reading of selected dialogues, interactions, and narrative moments, the study will examine how the drama represents illness as a relational, emotional, and social experience rather than merely a medical condition. It will further explore how caregiving becomes a means through which gender roles, emotional expression, marital commitment, and individual agency are negotiated and redefined. Thus, the paper seeks to demonstrate how *Queen of Tears* offers a nuanced representation of illness and care, foregrounding the transformative potential of vulnerability and human connection.

Nation-Building through Exclusion: Gendered Trauma and "Bare Life" in Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale*

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A nation may promise unity, stability, and belonging, yet its foundations can be built upon controlled bodies, silenced voices, and unseen wounds. Although nation-building is often discussed through institutions, identity, and social cohesion, less attention is paid to the trauma produced when the state defines citizens through their biological usefulness. This paper addresses that gap by examining gendered trauma as a consequence of exclusionary nation-building. Drawing on Giorgio Agamben's concept of "bare life," the study explores how sovereign power can reduce rights-bearing individuals to bodies that may be regulated, used, and exposed to violence. Margaret Atwood's *The Handmaid's Tale* represents this process through the Republic of Gilead, where fertile women are stripped of their names, professions, families, citizenship, and bodily autonomy. Their reproductive capacity becomes a national resource, while political and religious discourse recasts coercion as purity, duty, motherhood, and survival. Through a close reading of Offred's fragmented memories, silences, fear, and acts of remembrance, the paper investigates how authoritarian governance turns trauma into an instrument of discipline. It also examines how her narration functions as a counter-discourse, preserving individual memory against the state's attempt to control historical truth and erase marginalized experience. The paper argues that nation-building cannot be inclusive or sustainable when social order depends on reproductive exploitation, psychological violence, and unequal citizenship. Ultimately, Atwood reveals that when a nation secures its future by reducing women to useful bodies, its promise of order becomes inseparable from violence, erasure, and trauma.

Negotiating Care, Selfhood, and Maternal Agency in Anuradha Roy's Fiction

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Motherhood has conventionally been associated with sacrifice, care, and moral responsibility, often leaving little room to acknowledge women's individual aspirations and emotional contradictions. This paper examines how Anuradha Roy's *An Atlas of Impossible Longing* and *All the Lives We Never Lived* challenge these assumptions by portraying motherhood as an evolving and contested experience shaped by historical, familial, and cultural forces. Drawing on feminist perspectives on motherhood alongside Indian feminist thought, the study explores how Roy's maternal characters negotiate the competing demands of caregiving, personal identity, and social expectation. While some women remain deeply embedded within patriarchal notions of maternal duty, others seek spaces for self-expression that unsettle conventional understandings of what constitutes a "good" mother. Rather than presenting maternal agency as a simple act of resistance, Roy reveals it as a complex process of negotiation marked by emotional ambivalence, attachment, compromise, and self-reflection. The paper argues that these contrasting maternal trajectories move beyond binary oppositions such as conformity and rebellion or fulfilment and refusal, instead foregrounding the fluid relationship between selfhood and care. By situating Roy's fiction within contemporary debates on motherhood in Indian English literature, the study demonstrates how her narratives broaden feminist discussions of maternal identity by recognising its cultural specificity and psychological complexity. In doing so, the paper suggests that motherhood in Roy's novels functions not as a fixed social identity but as a dynamic and continually negotiated experience that redefines women's agency within the postcolonial Indian context.

Insular Geographies and Experimental Separatism in the Speculative Fictions of Padmanabhan and Mackintosh

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Marilyn Frye in "Some Reflections on Separatism and Power" argues that men have a parasitic relationship with women due to their near-absolute access to women and their labour. Therefore, feminist politics, she concludes, must have an aspect of separation and "no-saying" for the assumption of power. Speculative fiction has proved conducive to the exploration of feminist separatist politics, providing a textual space to imagine a broad-spectrum of alternate values and communities. These thought experiments are also frequently located in a separate fictional geographical space, whether a different country or a completely different planet. How far removed these fictional terraforms, in conception and distance, are from familiar geography often is a measure of the separation of the fictional communities and their politics. Absolute separateness in the form of female exclusive "utopias," for instance, is often hosted in fantastical and far-off locales—Mary E. Bradley Lane's *Mizora* (1890) is set in the centre of the Earth and Charlotte Perkins Gilman's *Herland* (1915) exists in an Eden-like manicured "enormous garden." Islands, with their geographic and cultural insularity, have been a popular geography in such imaginaries of a separate and different political and communal order, providing an anchor in reality and possibility to, both, utopias and dystopias. Sophie Mackintosh in her *The Water Cure* (2018) and Manjula Padmanabhan in *The Island of Lost Girls* (2015) are two twenty-first-century speculative fictions that carve out a separate space for women and other minorities on islands. This paper proposes to closely examine how the geographical setting colours and enables the ideology and practice in both texts. The focal enquiry would be how the physical separateness of the island geography plays a part in the exploration of feminist ideological separateness here.

Situating 'Body' and Law in Trans Motherhood in India

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"They had never accepted me as a trans person but when I became a mother of a five-year-old they accepted my motherhood", said the transgender activist, Gauri Sawant, in an interview on her adopting a five year old girl. Scholars have intensely produced research on the transgender community in multiple facets, ranging from body, gender, to kinship. However, the crucial existence of trans motherhood has not gained the same attention in Indian scholarship. The precarity of 'body' associated with sex and gender situates itself in another 'ideal' motif, that is, motherhood. The intersection of body and law provides autonomy, concurrently allowing and depriving transgender persons of their desire to experience motherhood and parenthood. The same law has the power to restrict and simultaneously uphold the rights of the citizens, especially for the marginalized community. Despite social ostracization, the grant of legal rights would be a boon for transgender persons, wherein they can assert their identity and at least fight for their place when denied. At the same time, the kind of body that deserves autonomy to become a mother is often determined by society and law. Hence, this paper interrogates and enquires about varied modalities of motherhood in the forms of biological parenthood, adoption, and guardianship through the selected cases of trans motherhood in India. Standing at the intersection of body and law, this paper raises pertinent questions: How do trans mothers and trans parents locate the creation of a non-traditional family? How does law break and shape the ideation of motherhood in the lives of transgender persons? The goal of this study is not merely to locate and fill the lacuna in the scholarship but primarily to underscore the need for the idea of motherhood to transcend the setting of only cisgender women in heterosexual marriages.

Panel 8:
Gender, Caste, Education and Digital Empowerment

Caste, Cultural Policy, and the Digital Construction of Bharatanatyam's Public Image in Contemporary India

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Bharatanatyam, an Indian Classical Dance form, known as Sadir attam or Dasi attam, has undergone significant transformations over the past century, yet questions of caste, cultural legitimacy, and representation continue to shape its contemporary public image. Focusing on the intersections of caste and performance, the paper identifies three significant changes of the art: the traditional structure during the colonial period, the transformative structure of the Liberalisation, Privatisation & Globalisation (LPG) era, and the drastic changes of cultural policy brought about by the rapid expansion of digital platformisation, following the COVID-19 pandemic. More recently, marginalized performers have used social media and digital platforms to articulate how Bharatanatyam's reform movements have shaped their artistic lineages and lived experiences. For example, Bharatanatyam dancer and writer Nrithya Pillai, who belongs to the Isai Vellalar community, argues that twentieth-century reform movements led by upper-caste elites sought to "sanitize" the art form. Drawing on the frameworks of Yudhishthir Raj Isar, Michel Foucault, and Pierre Bourdieu, this paper argues that cultural policy, diplomacy, and digital media simultaneously expand visibility while reproducing historical hierarchies of caste and cultural capital. Rather than treating digital platforms as neutral spaces of democratization, the paper investigates how algorithms, institutional networks, and historical-political power relations shape authenticity, visibility, and access within contemporary India. By bringing together caste studies, performance studies, digital media ethnography, and cultural policy analysis, this research contributes to ongoing debates on the relationship between technology, structural inequality, and cultural sustainability.

From Digital Access to Economic Agency: Re-examining Women's Empowerment in India's Digital Financial Ecosystem

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The rapid expansion of digital financial technologies has significantly transformed financial systems in emerging economies, creating new opportunities for financial inclusion, socio-economic development and social transformation. In India, initiatives such as the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY), the JAM (Jan Dhan-Aadhaar-Mobile) framework, and the growth of the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) have played a crucial role in expanding access to formal financial services and integrating individuals into the digital financial ecosystem. However, despite significant improvements in financial access, gender disparities persist in the effective and independent use of digital financial services. This study examines whether the expansion of digital financial infrastructure in India has translated into meaningful economic agency for women. Using secondary data from institutional reports, policy documents and existing empirical studies, the paper analyses trends in digital financial inclusion, digital payments and the expanding fintech ecosystem, while examining the extent to which these developments contribute to women's financial participation and economic empowerment. Particular attention is given to structural barriers, including limited digital and financial literacy, restricted access to digital devices and connectivity, concerns regarding digital security, and persistent socio-cultural constraints. The analysis indicates that although digital financial systems have substantially expanded women's access to formal financial services, the transition from digital access to meaningful economic agency remains uneven. Access to an account or digital payment facility does not necessarily translate into independent usage, control over financial resources, participation in financial decision-making or improved economic opportunities. Bridging this gap requires policies that move beyond access-oriented approaches towards strengthening digital capabilities, improving women's access to digital infrastructure, enhancing financial literacy, and promoting gender-inclusive financial innovation. By connecting digital financial inclusion with women's economic agency, the study contributes to the broader discourse on social equity, inclusive development and social transformation in India.

From Gender Bias to Gender Awareness in Educators: A Non-Binary Approach

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Having a clear insight about gender, including sex, gender identity and sexual orientation issues can help educators in spreading gender awareness. When discussions arise concerning gender inequality or the inclusion of diverse genders, these terms consistently come to mind. This study addresses the importance of awareness among educators, which can result in creating a gender-neutral educational environment for both sexual minority students and cisgender students. This paper offers evidence-based answers to myths and false beliefs about LGBTQ+ individuals on the basis of biological, psychological and educational research. Finally, to determine the existing opinions of educators about sexual diversity, a survey was conducted with 10 educators and 17 students of Chandigarh University. On the basis of the survey results, we were able to determine the level of gender awareness among educators, which can further help in planning better educational policies. Along with that this paper throws light on the fact that the need of studying the entire LGBTQ+ community together.

Gender Equality in Higher Education: A Survey-Based Study of College Students' Perceptions in Jaipur

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Gender equality is a basic and essential component of social equity and inclusive social development. Despite increasing awareness in society, Traditional gender roles and stereotypes continue to have an impact on how people think about education, employment possibilities, leadership, and social obligations. Higher education has a significant impact on influencing young adults' perspectives and fostering critical thinking on gender inequities. The study adopts a descriptive survey-based research design and proposes to collect data from college students across selected higher education institutions in Jaipur through a structured questionnaire. The questionnaire focuses on four major dimensions: equal educational and career opportunities, gender roles and stereotypes, leadership and decision-making, and the role of higher education in promoting gender equality. Responses will be collected using a five-point Likert scale and analysed through frequencies and percentages. The survey examines whether students support gender equality in social life and whether traditional gender assumptions continue to shape their perceptions. The study focuses on Jaipur college students to add to conversations on social equality, behavioral and cultural transformation, and higher education's role in inclusive social systems.

Mindful Learning for Sustainable Living: Integrating Environmental Ethics into Education

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Environmental Ethics is the study of normative issues and principles relating to human interactions with the natural environment and to their context and consequences (Attfield, 1983). To integrate environmental ethics and foster behavioral change through education involves adopting a multidimensional approach that combines knowledge, values, and actions. Mindful learning framework is an organized set of principles to extend thinking and expand learning in a tangible framework and its principles involve mindfulness, positive thinking, mindset, metacognition, critical thinking, creative thinking and meditation (Jackson, 2023). Mindfulness is constituted by the psychological states of openness to novelty, alertness to distinction, sensitivity to different contexts, implicit, if not explicit, awareness of multiple perspectives and orientation in the present (Burpee & Langer, 2005; Langer, 1997). Current study focuses on exploring and understanding approaches in building awareness and moral responsibility towards the environment by incorporating sustainable actions and promoting mindful learning in our educational system.

Panel 9:
Vernacular Worlds: Culture, Region and Collective Identity

A Contemporary Socio-Cultural Study of Hill-stations in Garhwal: Memory, Identity and Co-existence

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In an ever-changing societal grandstand where waves of ethnic trends keep changing their pace, there still remains a flickering glimpse of cultural neurosis, an agitation to conceal local ways, in fear of exposing them to a dominant sophistication of the West. It is the same consciousness that has been carried forward after the ravishing exploitation by colonial powers ever since an independent country could remember, many generations in their own times have always looked for a linguistic and cultural disguise in order to leave a mortal impact in the name of modernity, always seeking a niche under a dominant 'Videshi' tradition and concealing the unrecognised treasures their ancestors have bestowed upon them, the same about what Devy asserts in his remarkable essay "After Amnesia". The world has gradually been developing a multilingual structure, with it comes a fusion of cultural spaces that could only be interpreted through a capitalist phenomenon of 'global carnival'. However, with the collision of uncanny diversities, there is always a risk of marginalising or even losing associated local values and traditions From the cherished festival of "Hariyali" in Himanchal and Churia Ghats to the "Vasant Phooldei" carnival in Garhwal, foothills of Himalayas are home to diversified rejoicings. Acknowledgement of seasons is expressed through delightful customs and cuisine. Theatres, music industry and cinema of the state have contributed greatly in safeguarding cultural consciousness and maintained their prominence in the country. While, high form of literatures were written by either Anglo-Indians or the elevated class. The middle class natives were more fascinated by mimicry of the mainstream Indian cinema. The cultural representation was limited to theatres and folk music for a long period of time, spanning the late years of 20th century, these productions have been playing a prolific role in creating a vibrant sense of patriotism and pride in natives of remote villages of mountains. However, History, irrespective of the time

frame, galore the instances where the mountains have been subjected to metamorphic transitions. The paper intends to discuss various printed texts, articles and visual narratives that essentially carry a sense of cultural consciousness and will dwell into the theoretical premises of folk literature, new historicism, and film studies. Thus, the research will not only aim at exploring unheard practices, folklores and narratives of the marginalised through visual and written narratives, it will also investigate the position of hill-centric literature and cinema within the wide corpus of mainstream Indian-representations.

Beyond the Frame: *Padmavati* and *Bani-Thani* as Cultural Touchstones and Archive of Cultural Sustainability, Agency and Empowerment

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A milestone in oral tradition, Malik Mohammad Jayasi's epic poem *Padmavati* is a tale of honour, rebellion, and victory. It weaves a tragic tapestry of love and suffering where princess Padmavathi goes through a series of unspeakable doldrums of losing the supreme love of her life and experiences the curse of embodying heavenly beauty. She exemplifies the power of silent rebellion to combat the heinous tyranny of Allauddin Khilji. Her deliberate attempt of choosing to perform Jauhar makes her an unforgettably mighty cultural icon in the history of Rajput culture. Her self sacrifice becomes a cultural touchstone for Rajput women that displays pure feminine sensibility with the shades of insurmountable feminine dominance that underscore her autonomy and agency in patriarchal Society. Similarly, *Bani-Thani*, a synonym of ultimate feminine grace comes beyond the frame to affirm her identity as an indigenous cultural icon. *Bani-Thani* is the most endeared representation of Indian art which inspires literary texts, thus highlighting how art sustains literature and vice versa. Through moving beyond their image of ideal feminine beauty, this paper proposes to investigate them as gendered discourses and how they have helped in cultural sustainability. The analysis also deconstructs silence as a form of power, rather than weakness. Additionally, This paper uncovers the hidden power dynamics, and agency in these two artistic -literary canons.

From Vernacular Voice to Nation-Building: Social Transformation and Environmental Sustainability in the Folksongs of Narendra Singh Negi

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A Nation is fundamentally a reflection of its people, shaped by their past struggles, cultural traditions, and aspirations. In a culturally diverse and linguistically plural nation as India, nation-building extends beyond political and economic development towards cultural preservation and ecological responsibility. The vernacular discourse and local dialects constitute an integral part of this cultural fabric, carrying societal beliefs, viewpoints and lived experiences through oral traditions. Folksongs serve as traditional songs of a community which bind communities together. Within the discourse of Uttarakhand, Narendra Singh Negi emerged as the Himalayan voice of cultural expression, employing Garhwali language to foreground regional realities. The song albums of Negi depict rural and subaltern lives, social inequalities, migration, alcoholism, Kargil war, cultural change, and environmental deterioration. Despite scholarly work on Garhwali literature, folk culture and women empowerment in Garhwal, less attention is paid towards the role of Narendra Singh Negi's folksongs in articulating social transformation and environmental concerns. This paper examines Negi's songs as a medium that transforms vernacular expression into social commentary bringing social concerns and ecological anxieties into public consciousness. It examines songs addressing alcoholism and deterioration of the Ganga, encouraging social responsibility and meaningful change. The study employs a qualitative interpretative methodology, combining close textual, thematic, and auditory analysis of selected folksongs. Raymond Williams' cultural framework and Lawrence Buell's ecological perspective provide frameworks for examining culture and social negotiation. Negi's songs connect regional identity with sustainability and nation-building and demonstrates how vernacular expression contributes to a socially conscious and environmentally responsible society.

Voicing the Pahad: Uniyal's *Nanda Devi Express* and the Emerging Hip-Hop Culture of Uttarakhand

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The representation of Uttarakhand has often been shaped by images of the Himalayas, spirituality, natural beauty, and tourism. However, beneath this picturesque image lies a region facing interconnected social, political, and environmental concerns, including ecological degradation, overtourism, migration, unemployment, corruption, and inadequate development. This paper examines how contemporary hip-hop from Uttarakhand provides a counter-cultural space for articulating these concerns, with particular focus on Kartikey Uniyal's E.P. *Nanda Devi Express*. It argues that Uniyal uses hip-hop not merely as a musical form but as a medium through which the frustrations, anxieties, and aspirations of the region's youth are transformed into social and political commentary. The paper analyses the use of language, sampling, regional cultural references, rhythm, and performance to examine how hip-hop constructs a distinctly Uttarakhandi voice. It further situates Uniyal's work alongside selected songs by Tarun Bisht, Saksham Dhyani, Aniket Raturi, and other hip-hop artists from Uttarakhand who engage with similar social, political, cultural, and environmental concerns. By examining these works together, the paper explores the emergence of a socially conscious Pahadi hip-hop discourse that challenges the dominant tourist-oriented and picturesque representation of the region. It suggests that this music functions as a regional counter-narrative through which young artists reclaim the authority to represent their lived realities and negotiate questions of identity, belonging, ecological anxiety, and political dissatisfaction. Uttarakhand hip-hop thus emerges as an important contemporary cultural space where global hip-hop conventions are localised to express regional experiences, transforming youth frustration into cultural agency, social critique, and regional consciousness.

Panel 10:

Rethinking Conservation, Corporate Exploitation, and Ecological Labor

Beyond Anthropocentric Sustainability: The Ethics of Multispecies Coexistence in the Sundarbans

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The Sundarbans, the Land of Eighteen Tides, is the largest mangrove forest in the world. This forest has 'laws' which needs to be revered by the human inhabitants of the Sundarbans, and disrespect of which might cost them their lives. Further, belief in the myth of the forest deity, Bonobibi situates the human inhabitants and the tigers, in the Sundarbans, in a kinship. This paper argues for a reconceptualization of sustainability through multispecies coexistence, positioning the more-than-human landscape of the Sundarbans and its traditional belief system as an example of how sustainability is not just about the future of the humans, but also of the nonhuman nature. Rather than framing sustainability solely in terms of conservation or development, the paper explores it as an ethical practice of coexistence grounded in interdependence, reciprocity and shared vulnerability. This study adopts an interdisciplinary framework using various tenets of Animal Studies, ecocriticism and ecospirituality. A close textual analysis of certain literary works based on the Sundarbans will also be taken up to help in a better understanding of the primary argument of the study. Lastly, this study will unravel how in the name of development, drifting away from the traditional belief system has led to severe ecological disturbances in the Sundarbans. In doing so, this study contributes to contemporary debates on sustainability by proposing a more inclusive ethical framework capable of addressing the intertwined challenges of biodiversity loss, climate change and human-wildlife conflict.

From Ecological Exploitation to Environmental Justice:
The Revival of Sustainability in Imbolo Mbue's *How Beautiful We Were*

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Imbolo Mbue's *How Beautiful We Were* (2021) presents a progressive narrative of corporate exploitation & community resistance set forth in a fictional village of Kosawa.By examining the destructive presence of the American oil Corporation,Pexton,this study investigates how corporate exploitation dismantles Indigenous livelihood, economies, poisons hydrological ecosystems, and cripples the bonds between land and community. Kosawa represents real- world "Sacrifice zones" (such as the Niger Delta or Ecuador 's Lago Agrio Oil Field) where Western corporations extract natural resources with absolute disregard for local lives.The novel highlights the violent synergy between foreign capital and corrupt local governance. This paper uses ideas from Ecocriticism and Political Ecology to study how Imbolo Mbue portrays the community's relationship with nature.It evaluates the multi-generational shift in resistance strategies—from traditional diplomatic appeals and educational activism to interrogate the limits of nonviolent protest against corporate power practice. Ultimately, this study demonstrates how How Beautiful We Were presents Corporate exploitation as an incessant practice of historic colonial systems. By highlighting the collective voice of Kosawa's youth, Mbue's work redefines sustainability not merely as resource management, but as an urgent, non-negotiable move for human rights, land sovereignty, and environmental justice.

The Security–Ecology Trade-Off in Himalayan Road Widening: A Proposed Threshold Framework

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Himalayan road infrastructure is vital for connecting communities, supporting tourism and pilgrimage, enabling emergency access, and meeting strategic-security needs. Yet the region's fragile terrain makes road widening particularly sensitive, as associated disaster and social risks may fall disproportionately on local communities. Existing discussions around Himalayan road development have been framed as a tension between security and development on the one hand and environmental protection on the other. Such a binary framing overlooks the fact that strategic needs and ecological risks vary across locations. This paper explores the environmental pressures created by security and development activities in the Himalayan region and the challenges they pose to environmental sustainability. The study is qualitative in nature and draws on case studies related to Himalayan road-widening projects. The study sheds light on how benefits and risks are distributed and considers whether affected communities are recognised. It considers how strategic-security requirements interact with ecological vulnerability, disaster risk, and community concerns across different locations. The study proposes a conceptual Security–Ecology Threshold Framework in which increasing ecological vulnerability, disaster risk, and community exposure call for stronger strategic-security justification for road widening. Environmental justice complements this framework by examining how benefits and risks are distributed, whether affected communities are recognised, and how they participate in decision-making. This framework suggests that road widening in more vulnerable locations requires stronger justification. It also calls for better safeguards, consideration of alternatives, and attention to the concerns of local communities. The proposed framework highlights the need for road-widening decisions to account for both strategic requirements and location-specific ecological and social risks. Future research can test the framework using location-specific data.

Panel 11:

Displacement, Loss, and Literary Environmental Justice

Fragile Ecologies: Environmental Injustice, Social Inequality, and Displacement in Contemporary Indian Literature

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Climate change and environmental degradation are not merely ecological problems; they are also social problems. They are closely connected to questions of human survival, social inequality, and displacement. In India, environmental changes often affect people from marginalised positions, especially people who depend directly on natural resources like forests, land, and rivers. Literature has represented environmental problems through communities, memories and struggles for belonging. Contemporary Indian literature has offered significant possibilities to examine the relationship between ecological crisis and social justice. This study focuses on Nilanjana Roy's *Black River* (2022) and Janice Pariat's *Everything the Light Touches* (2022) to investigate how environmental vulnerability is connected with social inequality. Both works are entirely different in narrative form and geographical setting. The study aims to examine the representations of environmental injustice and displacement in the selected works, which analyses how social factors such as caste, gender and access to resources influence environmental vulnerability, and it explores how the transformation has affected identity, belonging and livelihood. The main hypothesis of the study is that environmental crises are experienced different social groups, with marginalised communities being more vulnerable to ecological degradation of their cultural ties to place. The study will use qualitative textual analysis and comparative close reading of the selected primary texts. For the Theoretical Framework, this study will use Environmental Justice, Postcolonial criticism and displacement studies. By bringing these approaches together, the research seeks to demonstrate that contemporary Indian literature does not merely represent environmental destruction but also reveals the unequal social structures through which environmental crises are experienced.

Beyond the Royal Victory: Environmental Destruction and Subaltern Grief in *After Kurukshetra*

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Mahasweta Devi's *After Kurukshetra* shifts attention away from the Mahabharata's triumphant royal victories to the quiet suffering endured by nature and ordinary people. Whereas traditional epics celebrate statecraft and royal duty (rajavritta), this paper examines how war causes widespread environmental devastation, including burnt forests, ruined farmland and lost livelihoods. Focusing on stories such as The Five Women and Kunti and the Nishadin, the study emphasises the grief of peasant and indigenous women whose lives are intimately bound to the land.Through a clear ecocritical perspective, the paper shows that their grief goes beyond personal heartbreak; it acts as a silent protest against the loss of natural resources and communal stability. In the end, Mahasweta Devi uses these narratives to show that real sustainability requires caring for local habitats and valuing the lived experiences of everyday people.

Climate Inequality, Displacement and Environmental Justice in Téa Obreht's *The Morningside*

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Contemporary climate fiction is an emerging genre that has reoriented the focus from only depicting the environment and the nature of the problem of climate change as a pure ecological crisis to depicting the uneven effects of similar climate change that result in social consequences as well. Téa Obreht's *The Morningside* (2024), a dystopian climate fiction based in a partially submerged Island City that is also environmentally deteriorating, raises important questions. Shortlisted for the inaugural 2025 Climate Fiction Prize, it not only address but also creatively explore the real and potential impacts of a change in climate. Reading the novel through Robert Bullard's environmental justice theory, David Pellow's account of the structural and systemic dimensions of environmental harm, and Rob Nixon's concept of slow violence, this study argues that these three frameworks jointly reveal how *The Morningside* represents climate catastrophe as a socially distributed event rather than a uniform one. Bullard's framework anchors an analysis of climate-induced displacement in the novel; Pellow's work illuminates how ecological degradation, housing insecurity, class, and unequal access to safe spaces are structurally connected; and Nixon's slow violence accounts for how the gradual submergence of Island City and the prolonged Repopulation Program embed environmental harm into the fabric of everyday life, rendering it less visible even as its effects accumulate. The transformation of the Morningside from a place of status and privilege to an abandoned habitat, illustrates the precariousness of safety once environmental conditions turn hostile and how climate disaster reconfigures the meanings of home, community, and belonging. In bringing environmental justice criticism into conversation with *The Morningside*, this study extends the climate fiction genre's engagement with social inequality and its consequences.

Discourse, Displacement and the Politics of Belonging in Amitav Ghosh's *The Hungry Tide*

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Moving at the intersection of a transnational environmental conservation discourse and the project of nation-building, this paper reads Amitav Ghosh's *The Hungry Tide* (2004) as a literary intervention in that story. Focusing on the intersection of a transnational environmental conservation discourse and the project of nation-building, this paper reads Amitav Ghosh's *The Hungry Tide* (2004) as a literary intervention in that story. Focusing on the Morichjhapi episode in which refugee settlements established on protected Sundarbans land are evacuated the study explores how the language of conservation discourse performs differential valuation of human and animal life, and delineates who can be included in the national territory. Drawing on Michel Foucault's understanding of power/knowledge and on Rob Nixon's concept of slow violence, the study uses qualitative discourse analysis to interrogate three competing discursive registers within the novel: official/scientific speak, Nirmal's poetic autobiography, and the oral history of the settlers. The paper finds that the novel lends fiction to a scientific and bureaucratic regime, and that literature can serve as a form of archival record where state-speak is silenced. It ends by asking what such fiction can contribute to a just and inclusive model of sustainability discourse.

Panel 12:
Education, Value Building and the Making of Social Futures

Bharatanatyam-Inspired Movement for Nurturing Emotional Intelligence in Children: An Indian Knowledge Systems–Based Educational Approach

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In the context of rapid digitalization, fragmented attention, and increasing dependence on technology-mediated learning, developing children's emotional and cognitive capacities has become an important concern in contemporary education. This paper explores the potential of Bharatanatyam-inspired movement as a simple, culturally grounded classroom approach for nurturing emotional intelligence among children aged 8–11 years. Drawing from selected principles of the *Nāṭya Śāstra*, including posture, rhythm, hand gestures, facial expressions, and embodied representation, the study adapts traditional movement elements into age-appropriate classroom activities that do not require formal dance training. These activities are integrated with storytelling, guided movement, emotional identification, and reflection to create structured learning modules aimed at supporting children's awareness and expression of emotions, self-regulation, attention, empathy, and interpersonal understanding. Informed by perspectives from Cognitive Psychology and Emotional Intelligence, the study adopts an interdisciplinary framework connecting Indian Knowledge Systems (IKS) with contemporary approaches to holistic education. The developed modules will be implemented, observed, and refined through a one-year exploratory intervention involving children in the target age group. The study seeks to examine the feasibility, acceptability, and educational potential of Bharatanatyam-inspired movement as a practical classroom resource for emotional development. By translating selected traditional knowledge elements into accessible educational practices, the research contributes to ongoing discussions on culturally responsive pedagogy, embodied learning, and the integration of Indian Knowledge Systems into contemporary school education. The proposed framework has potential for adaptation across diverse educational settings as a low-cost, participatory, and culturally meaningful approach to supporting children's socio-emotional development.

Fostering Sustainable Nation Building through Educational Psychology: Exploring Learner Motivation, Well-Being, and Value Development in Higher Education

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Prof Santosh Arora
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Educational psychology offers a meaningful lens for understanding how higher education can contribute to sustainable nation building. In a rapidly changing world, universities are not only centers of knowledge but also spaces where young people develop motivation, emotional balance, ethical awareness, and social responsibility. This paper examines the role of learner motivation, well-being, and value development in shaping students who can participate actively in the creation of a just, resilient, and sustainable society. It argues that education must go beyond academic achievement and support the overall growth of learners as thoughtful citizens. Motivated students are more likely to engage deeply in learning, while emotional well-being helps them cope with stress, adapt to challenges, and maintain positive relationships. At the same time, the development of values such as cooperation, empathy, integrity, and respect strengthens their commitment to the larger social good. The paper highlights that educational psychology can guide teaching practices, classroom climate, and institutional policies that encourage meaningful learning and responsible behavior. By promoting learner-centered approaches, supportive environments, and value-based education, higher education can prepare youth to contribute to national progress in a sustainable way. Thus, educational psychology becomes a powerful foundation for building not only successful learners but also socially responsible and future-ready citizens.

From Impulse to Insight: Emotionally Intelligent Citizens as Architects of India's Journey to Viksit Bharat

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Sustainable nation-building is not determined solely by economic progress, technological advancement and institutional development; it also depends on the emotional and behavioural capacities of the individuals who constitute society. Emotional intelligence plays a significant role in enabling individuals to recognise, understand, and regulate their emotions and to respond to challenging situations with greater awareness and reflection. The paper draws on ideas from the humanities and social sciences to frame emotional intelligence as something much broader than personal effectiveness. At its core, it's about empathy, self-awareness, understanding others, ethical reflection, and being a responsible citizen. The discussion looks closely at how emotions like anger, fear, frustration, jealousy and anxiety, when left unregulated, can distort the way we perceive situations, make judgements and arrive at decisions. By contrast, when emotions are consciously regulated, they open up space for reflection, for seeing things from another person's point of view, and for responding in more balanced ways. The paper focuses on how cognitive reappraisal, self-reflection and empathy help turn a raw, immediate emotional reaction into a more thoughtful, constructive course of action. The paper proposes a conceptual pathway: Emotional Intelligence -> Emotion Regulation -> Reflective Decision-Making -> Responsible Behaviour -> Individual Well-being -> Social Transformation -> Sustainable Nation Building for empowering individuals with emotional and reflective competencies, which can strengthen social cohesion and contribute to the dream of Viksit Bharat @2047 with not only intelligent and technologically capable citizens but also emotionally intelligent individuals capable of transforming emotions into responsible action.

Sanskrit Lexicography Today – Aspect of a Multidimensional Lexicon

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Sanskrit lexicography entered its modern phase with the arrival of colonial era's bilingual dictionaries and has since grown into a wide and varied tradition. This paper surveys that modern era, beginning with early works such as Wilson's Sanskrit-English Dictionary, and moving through landmark dictionaries including Goldstucker, Benfey, Monier Williams (1872, 1899), Apte's The Practical Sanskrit-English Dictionary. It also covers Sanskrit-German dictionaries (Böhtlingk & Roth's Grosses Petersburger Wörterbuch, and Sanskrit monolingual koshas such as Vacaspatyam and Shabda Kalpadruma. The study further shows how the tradition expanded beyond general dictionaries into domain-specific vocabulary through specialized reference works such as Sorensen's Mahabharata Index and Macdonell's Vedic Index. The paper then moves into the present digital era, looking at platforms such as the Cologne Digital Sanskrit Dictionaries (CDSL), the CSTT's Shabd Portal, and the Digital Corpus of Sanskrit (DCS), along with corpus building tools such as the IL Crawler and IL Dictionary that are essential for Sanskrit lexical work. Each dictionary added depth in method, coverage, or language pairing, yet most modern Sanskrit dictionaries, including many digital platforms raises a central question for the field what should a Sanskrit dictionary entry look like in the digital age? This paper opens up discussion, working toward identifying the essential dimensions a modern entry may need, such as standardized part-of-speech tagging, core meaning, usage examples (classical or modern), etymology, synonyms, subject domain, and source citation etc. On usage examples specifically, the question is whether they should be drawn only from classical texts for authenticity, or should also include contemporary usage to show Sanskrit as a living language. Rather than settling this question, the paper explores it, building on the strengths and gaps of the surveyed tradition, as well as the possibilities offered by present day digital tools, to work toward a practical framework for future Sanskrit dictionary entries, one that is more structured, linguistically informed, and suited to the digital and computational age.

AI and Decolonization Movement in Academia: Mapping the Legacy of Tech on Humanities

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India and the countries that have faced colonization are still struggling with traces of colonization that hunts even the civic life of the day in these countries. This is not only because Colonizers exploited Economy and Trade of these country but also they ruined and corrupted the identity and History of these countries just for their instrumental objectivity. They corrupted history and knowledge system first for dividing the people so that they could rule and secondly for legitimizing their exploitation through categorization of Civilized – Uncivilized. These same categories were once more advocated on the name of development and Modernity through categorization of Developed, Developing and Underdeveloped status. But Today when India and other decolonized Nations are asserting their lens to project their understanding rather of Western lens. Then and their coming of AI and its uses in the form of researching tool to knowledge production becomes significant because the coding is being imparted the Western Countries no one the other . This paper critically engages with the relation of AI and Decolonization movement which have become popular in the humanities especially just after the announcement of Panchpran by Narendra Modi, the prime minister of India on 15 august ,2022.Through critical discourse analysis this paper carries a comparative account between dominance of Western anecdotes and algorithm that Artificial Intelligence uses to know that Is the information which are easily available in more nuanced way on single tick through AI replicate the colonial understanding about the concerned Knowledge or Is it balanced? Using theoretical understanding of Epistemic Injustice, the New JIM Code as well Data Colonization this papers provides thought provoking account on the relevance of doing Humanities without AI or with conscious understanding in India. This paper is relevant in making awareness about the slippery slope for those who just for the sake of the decolonizing and rewriting Indian history and Humanities using AI as their ultimate source of knowledge. This paper will not be only helpful in creating awareness about AI and dominance of Western episteme but also will be enriching the Panchpran announced by Indian Prime Minister as foundational Principles for Viksit Bharat @2047.

Panel 13:
Fostering Strong Voices: Probing Issues in Classroom Communication

Neuro-Inclusive Pedagogy: Intersecting Neuroscience, Technology, and ELT for Sustainable Nation Building

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English proficiency functions as critical social capital for global participation and sustainable nation-building. However, its acquisition is heavily influenced by English's intense orthographic complexity. Compounding this cognitive hurdle, traditional English Language Teaching (ELT) often relies on rigid rote memorization and grammar-translation methods, which inadvertently excludes neurodivergent readers. Reading is not an innate biological capability but a recently developed cultural habit that often repurposes neural circuits originally dedicated to auditory and speech perception. Early reading demands precise temporal coordination between neural processes that are responsible for phonological decoding, requiring a subsequent transition through a parietal "prosodic bridge." This intermediate stage requires the integration of sensory information like internal rhythm and pitch contours to facilitate meaning construction and resolve semantic ambiguities. Fostering interdisciplinary collaborations between neuroscience, educational technology, and ELT is paramount to bridging this gap. The study seeks to review the existing technological interventions for reading through a biolinguistic perspective. The findings suggest that the technological interventions enhance phonological processing efficiency by strengthening neurocognitive networks and promoting compensatory activation patterns. Implementing multisensory technological interventions, such as Text-To-Speech (TTS) and Speech-To-Text (STT) tools actively scaffold the brain's transition from early electrical decoding to the chemically (neurotransmitters) mediated, automatized learning required for skilled, semantic reading. Thus, to take a relook at the efficacy of technological interventions, this paper aims to offer a comprehensive neurobiological review of the effects of interventions and assistive technologies, highlighting the neural and behavioral outcomes while pointing to unresolved questions for future investigation.

From Doubt to Dialogue: Student Experiences of Questioning

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Questioning and seeking clarification are everyday classroom behaviours that are influenced not only by learning needs but also by psychological factors. This qualitative study explores students' experiences of asking questions and expressing doubts in the classroom, with particular attention to assertive communication. It intends to understand how students perceive their ability to speak up, ask for clarification, express a different opinion, or admit that they have not understood something. The study also explores psychological factors that may shape these behaviours, including self-confidence, self-efficacy, fear of negative evaluation, perceived teacher support, peer influence, and psychological safety. Semi-structured interviews will be conducted with students, and the data will be analysed thematically to identify recurring experiences and patterns. Rather than viewing assertiveness as an individual trait, the study considers how students' willingness to communicate may develop through their interactions with teachers and peers and their perception of the classroom environment. The findings may contribute to a better understanding of the psychological processes underlying student participation and academic help-seeking. The study also tries to compare how these experiences relate to the learner-centred and participatory vision of education outlined in NEP 2020. By highlighting students' voices, the study aims to understand what helps them feel psychologically comfortable to question, clarify, and participate actively in learning.

Rethinking Age in Second Language Acquisition: From Biological Foundations to Contemporary Perspectives on the Critical Period Hypothesis

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Second Language Acquisition (SLA) seeks to explain how learners acquire a non-native language and why language acquisition varies across individuals. Among various factors influencing SLA, age has remained one of the most debated variables, shaping whole discourse around the Critical Period Hypothesis (CPH) and studies on language acquisition. Despite its persistent impact, the role of age continues to enrich the theoretical debate regarding its significance in first and second language acquisition. The present paper critically investigates the evolution of the Critical Period Hypothesis from its biological foundations to contemporary perspectives. Particularly, it aims to (i) examine diverse theoretical perspectives on the effect of age in language acquisition, (ii) explore the relevance of the CPH in both first and second language acquisition, and (iii) critically analyse the implications of CPH for child and adult second language learners. The paper argues that language acquisition is best achieved by an inclusive outlook of neurological, cognitive, motivational, instructional, and contextual factors. Although limited to a theoretical synthesis without empirical investigation, this particular study contributes to ongoing debates by providing an integrated perspective that recontextualizes age as one of crucial dimensions within the complex process of language acquisition and discusses scope for future possibilities.

Panel 14:
Digital Humanities: New Forms of Narrative and Literary Culture

Beyond the Page: Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* and the Digital Transformation of Narrative

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The adaptation of literary texts into video games offers new possibilities for examining narrative, interactivity, and audience participation within the Digital Humanities. This study examines the transformation of J. R. R. Tolkien's *The Lord of the Rings* into interactive digital forms, focusing on *The Fellowship of the Ring*, *The Two Towers*, *The Return of the King*, and *Middle-earth: Shadow of Mordor*. It investigates how Tolkien's characters, settings, themes, and narrative structures are translated and reconfigured through gameplay, visual representation, sound, spatial design, and player interaction. The study has three objectives: to examine how Tolkien's literary world is adapted in selected video games; to analyse how digital technologies transform linear narration into interactive and spatial storytelling; and to explore how player agency reshapes the relationship between narrative and audience. A qualitative comparative methodology is employed, combining close reading of selected passages from *The Lord of the Rings* with textual, visual, spatial, and gameplay analysis. The study argues that these games are not merely reproductions of Tolkien's novels but digital reinterpretations that transform reading into participation. While the earlier adaptations condense Tolkien's narrative through mission-based gameplay and cinematic representation, *Shadow of Mordor* expands Middle-earth through open-world exploration and emergent storytelling. The study demonstrates that digital adaptation shifts the audience from reader to player, making narrative more interactive, spatial, and participatory.

Circulating the Counter-Discourse: (Re)framing *Karukku* in Digital Publics

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This paper examines Bama's magnum opus *Karukku* (1992) as a literary text that gives voice to Dalit experiences of social exclusion. Drawing on Nancy Fraser's concept of subaltern counterpublics and Michael Warner's ideas on publics, counterpublics, and the circulation of texts, the paper asks how *Karukku* creates a counter-discourse and, in particular, what happens to this discourse as the text enters digital spaces. Rather than treating the digitalisation of a literary narrative as simply converting a printed book into an electronic form, the study focuses on *Karukku's* wider digital circulation and discussion. The research utilizes the primary methodology of close textual reading of *Karukku* to identify its major forms of counter-social exclusion discourse and the methods the text implements to form and circulate a Dalit counterpublic. It is then followed by a qualitative digital discourse analysis of selected academic articles, university materials, literary reviews, reader responses, and other publicly available digital discussions of the text to investigate what happens to its counterpublic discourse as it moves across these digitally mediated publics. The study explores how different digital audiences represent Bama's voice, Dalit experience, and the issues raised by *Karukku.* It aims to discover whether digital circulation amplifies the reach of Bama's counter-discourse, transforms its understanding, or places it within new forms of institutionalized academic and public discussion. The paper ultimately discusses how the digitalization of humanities subjects can contribute to the visibility of marginalised voices and social equity.

Derived Dystopia: Cultural Replacement in Dave Eggers' *The Circle*

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The Internet with its ecosystem has become the driving force of societal cohesion in the 21st century. With all the data available to humans flowing into it, the internet has become a site of normalcy, a place that redefines the functionality of knowledge and poses itself as dependable and democratic. As such, people have started to rely on the space for everyday usage, navigating life and culture. While culture is "a whole way of life", and digital culture is undoubtedly a part of it, *The Circle* (2013) by American author Dave Eggers, finds digital culture to be structurally overdetermining rather than merely supplementary. As the novel deals with the transgression of digital cultural practices into everyday life, it uncovers human society naturally integrating the internet into every aspect of it. This paper juxtaposes digital culture and its effects against lived culture. The need to rationalise, arrange, systematise human life through data collection, algorithms, and objective interpretation of life seem like a priority to the internet and digital spaces. In *The Circle*, this becomes apparent when a powerful technology corporation, called the Circle, integrates social media, digital identity, surveillance systems, and e-commerce into a single, all-encompassing platform. *The Circle* demonstrates how digital infrastructures transform cultural behaviour, social relations and conceptions of knowledge. This paper intends to understand the need to replace subjective life with objective precision. By analysing Mae Holland's gradual internalisation of the Circle's values, the paper demonstrates how consent, pleasure, and moral language sustain this derived cultural dystopia by dismantling the ambiguous lived culture.

From Oral Memory to Algorithmic Memory: Digital Platforms and the Intergenerational Transmission of Cultural Knowledge in Uttarakhand

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Cultural knowledge is conventionally passed on among generations like stories, local traditions, proverbs,rituals and everyday community practices. In Uttarakhand, such form of information is closely connected with regional identity and collective memory of community life. This paper examines the transmission from interpersonal oral transmission to technology facilitated transmission and investigates how digital platforms may modify the cultural knowledge. Exploring upon the changing roles of elders as cultural educators.The involvement of young generation in digital platforms and the transformation of oral narratives through recording, translations, editing, and online circulation, particular attention will be given under the concept of algorithmic memory. We know that digital platforms can conserve and pass on the cultural knowledge.Yet the current debate on Algorithmic memory and transmission of knowledge arises on which forms of cultural knowledge becomes visible, what may remain marginal or invisible, who acquires authority to represent cultural memory, and how younger generations encounter and reinterpret traditions online. This paper fills this gap by discussing the community controlled representation, visibility of the marginalized knowledge via trend setting videos and ethical contextualized algorithmic memory. Furthermore, this study is descriptive in nature and gives qualitative research methodology based on primary data analysis through the method of semi structured interviews, oral history interviews, digital ethnography, focus group discussions and comparative analysis of traditional and digital transmission. The study thus considers digitalisation not simply as a tool for preserving the past, but as a process that can reshape how cultural memory is constructed and transmitted in contemporary society.

Panel 15:
Narratology within Digital Humanities and Algorithmic Computation

Mediating the Sacred and the Profane: The Affective Politics of Green Nation-building and Sustainability

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Ganga, mythologised as a sacred goddess descending from the heavens, is today one of the most polluted rivers, a precarious icon whose sacred and profane dimensions alike are rendered visible on Instagram, itself a profane digital medium. This paper argues that the Instagram page of the Namami Gange Programme, Namami Gange, articulates a continuous negotiation of the sacred and the profane, mediating them through a culturally specific affective politics of green nation-building and sustainability. Using cultural discourse analysis and multimodal analysis, the paper treats India as a distinctive site of environmental meaning-making, attending to the affective dimensions of identity, place-based patterns of signification, and the page's bilingual strategy. Through a close reading of 100 posts bounded by hashtags #Ganga, #NamamiGange, and #SaveGanga from Namami Gange, the analysis identifies three interlinked discursive patterns: the sacred, the profane, and official green nationalism. The sacred is rendered through mythic reference, sacred geography, and ritual worship, borrowing legitimacy from an older, non-state devotional map of the nation. The profane operates in two registers: as a contaminating matter of sewage, plastic, and ritual waste; and in the institutional domain of sewage treatment infrastructure and urban river management. Nation-building operates as a form of official green nationalism, providing normative orientations for citizen conduct expressed through sustainable development and civic participation. The nation-building discourse amalgamates the river's figure as a goddess and lifeblood with neoliberal notions of individualised environmental participation in which recycling and waste segregation are folded into a value-based civilisational discourse of duty.

Reinventing Narrativity under Digital Humanities: An Inquiry into Transmedial Narratology and Theorization from Print to Electronic Literature

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The rapid expansion of digital technologies has not only altered the ways in which literature is produced and consumed but has also compelled the humanities to reconsider some of its most fundamental concepts. Narratives that once relied primarily on the stability of the printed page are increasingly shaped by digital platforms, interactive interfaces, multimedia forms, and participatory readerships. In this context, this study explores how narrativity is being reimagined within the emerging interdisciplinary space of Digital Humanities, particularly through the theoretical possibilities of transmedial narratology. Drawing upon established narratological perspectives and contemporary scholarship on electronic literature, the study examines the movement from print to digital narrative as more than a technological transition. It considers how changes in the medium reshape our understanding of temporality, spatiality, focalisation, authorship, textuality, interactivity, and reader participation. Undertaking E-lit literary works as primary texts, the paper argues that electronic literature does not necessarily displace the literary traditions of print; rather, it extends and reconfigures them, creating new forms of engagement between text, technology, author, and reader. The paper further reflects on the role of the humanities in preserving cultural narratives while responding meaningfully to technological change. Digital literary practices can facilitate wider access to cultural memory, encourage participatory forms of knowledge-making, and provide new spaces for diverse voices and experiences. Thus, transmedial narratology emerges not merely as a theoretical framework for analysing changing literary forms, but as a means of understanding how the humanities can remain responsive, inclusive, and socially relevant in a rapidly transforming world.

Maithili Translation & Study of "Mṛcchakaṭikam" in the Context of AI Integration and Cultural Adaptation

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Artificial The present study, titled "Maithili Translation and Study of Mṛcchakaṭikam in the Context of AI Integration and Cultural Adaptation," focuses on two major dimensions: translation and cultural adaptation. The translation of Sanskrit literature into Maithili establishes a meaningful connection between two important literary traditions. Sanskrit, with its rich classical literary heritage, provides an important source for enriching regional-language literature, while Maithili, as a regional language of the Mithila region, requires continuous development and preservation of its literary resources. Translating classical Sanskrit texts into Maithili can therefore contribute to the promotion of both languages by making Sanskrit literary works accessible to Maithili-speaking readers and strengthening the literary corpus of Maithili. The second major dimension of the study is cultural adaptation, which refers to the adaptation of the cultural, social, and contextual elements of Mṛcchakaṭikam to the Maithili cultural context while preserving the essential meaning and literary spirit of the original Sanskrit text. Since the play reflects the social and cultural conditions of its historical period, its translation for contemporary readers requires careful consideration of the differences between the society represented in the text and the cultural context of the 21st century. Customs, social relationships, values, traditions, idiomatic expressions, and other culture-specific elements therefore require contextual interpretation rather than merely literal translation. The study further examines the role of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in Sanskrit–Maithili translation. Although AI-assisted translation can facilitate the translation process, it faces challenges in understanding context-specific meanings, idiomatic expressions, cultural references, and the natural linguistic usage of Maithili. A comparative examination of AI-generated translations, including outputs from tools such as Google Translate and Bhashini, indicates variations in the interpretation and expression of the same Sanskrit text. Such variations highlight the importance of human intervention in evaluating and refining AI-generated translations. A human translator with knowledge of both Sanskrit and Maithili can ensure linguistic accuracy, contextual

appropriateness, natural expression, and cultural relevance. The study adopts a qualitative and descriptive methodology to analyse selected passages from Mṛcchakaṭikam, their AI-generated translations, and their cultural adaptation into Maithili. It explores both the possibilities and limitations of AI-assisted translation while emphasising the complementary role of human linguistic and cultural expertise. The study argues that the integration of AI technology with human knowledge can provide new possibilities for the translation, cultural adaptation, preservation, and wider dissemination of classical Sanskrit literature through Maithili.

Preserving the Civilisational Memory of the *Ramayana*: A Study in the Context of Digital Humanities

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The *Ramayana* is among the rare works of world literature that, over a journey of more than two millennia, has crossed the boundaries of language, script, region and religion, flowing on in over three hundred forms. This legacy lives in palm leaf, birch bark, temple walls, illustrated manuscripts, and oral and performative traditions passed down from generation to generation. Today, it is struggling against damp, insect damage, colonial-era dispersal, and the challenges of complex scripts. This study offers a qualitative assessment of the preservation initiatives undertaken between 2003 and 2026, the National Mission for Manuscripts, Project Ramayanam, the digital reunification of the Mewar Ramayana, DREAMSEA, and the efforts surrounding Cambodia's Reamker. These have undoubtedly strengthened accessibility and comparative research. Yet the limited OCR accuracy for scripts such as Grantha and Kawi, the incompatibility between collections, unequal resources, and the neglect of oral traditions remain obstacles even now. Most undertakings have been "preservation first"; they safeguard the text, but give readers no means to read it in a script of their choice or to compare its versions with one another. To fill this gap, the study proposes the concept of 'Ramayana Vaividhya Setu', an integrated multilingual platform. Built around the Valmiki Ramayana and the Ramcharitmanas, it will present the original text through transliteration rather than translation, rendering it faithfully in Devanagari, Gurmukhi, Bengali, Kannada, Tamil and other scripts. It will offer bidirectional search, comparative episode mapping, and a word-level dictionary; host copyright-free texts directly while linking protected texts to their original sources; and, with informed consent, bring in unwritten traditions such as Chhau, Wayang Kulit, and Ramlila as citable "tellings" on a par with textual versions. Its theoretical foundation is the "fluid text" concept of Doniger and Bryant, together with Ramanujan's view of tradition. In conclusion, the study charts a path that carries digital preservation beyond the static archive and establishes the *Ramayana* as a living, cross-referential knowledge system.

Panel 16:
AI and the Posthuman: Technology, Power and Algorithmic Life

From Silicon to Soil: Artificial Intelligence and Neuro-Technologies as Enablers of Ecological Empathy in Richard Powers' *Bewilderment* (2021)

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As ecological degradation and technological innovation increasingly shape the contemporary world, literature has begun to explore how emerging technologies may transform human relationships with the natural environment. Richard Powers' *Bewilderment* offers a compelling vision of ecological consciousness through the convergence of neuroscience, artificial intelligence, and environmental ethics. This study examines how the novel imagines neuro-technological interventions as catalysts for ecological empathy, enabling deeper emotional and cognitive connections between humans and the more-than-human world. The study, grounding on posthumanist discourse, particularly the work of N. Katherine Hayles and Rosi Braidotti, argues that *Bewilderment* challenges anthropocentric assumptions by presenting technology as a medium that extends ethical relations beyond the human. It also employs the Extended Mind Thesis proposed by Andy Clark and David Chalmers to interpret neuro-technologies as cognitive extensions that reshape perception, emotion, and ecological awareness. Through the experiences of Theo Byrne and his son Robin, Powers portrays advanced neurofeedback technologies that foster affective engagement with animal life and ecological interdependence. Insights from affect theory, particularly those of Brian Massumi, further illuminate how emotional resonance underpins ecological responsibility. The study argues that *Bewilderment* reimagines technological progress as a means of cultivating environmental awareness, multispecies ethics, and sustainable futures, demonstrating that innovation achieves its greatest significance when it deepens humanity's ethical relationship with the living world.

Recoding Discrimination: Posthuman Bias and Caste in Contemporary South Asian Speculative Fiction

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Posthuman fiction depicts worlds inhabited by enhanced humans, artificial intelligences, and societies governed by algorithms. Recent scholarship explores how such fictions re-imagine or reinforce structures of discrimination based upon race, gender, class, or species through a three-tier analytical frame: ontological, epistemological and ethical. Such an approach sheds valuable light on the representation of discrimination in posthuman fictions. However, the works discussed in such scholarship are almost exclusively Western, written in English. The concept of caste, a social hierarchy unique to South Asia, is a key component of post-colonial discourse on social discrimination. The present paper engages with the themes of discrimination in literature on post-human society by reading South Asian and Indian speculative fiction. The paper asks the question: How is the social hierarchy of caste re-articulated, reimagined or reiterated in post-humanist fictions? When a society governed by algorithms or designed by genetic engineering emerges, is there a place for caste in such a society? Does caste logic mutate into another form of discrimination based upon biologics? The paper argues that the fluidity of post-human subjectivity as assemblage enables the best approach to studying such questions. The paper uses the framework of ontological, epistemological and ethical discrimination as developed by recent scholarship, and applies it to works of Indian origin, thus exploring caste as the analogue of race and class in the context of post-humanist fiction. This approach fits within the conference theme of racism and its effects on society by expanding the scope of discussion to include other forms of social discrimination and its representation in literature.

Suspended Agency:
Algorithmic Governance and Moral Displacement in *Wrong Way*

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Joanne McNeil's *Wrong Way* (2023) stages the governance of gig labour through AllOver, a technology corporation of driverless car fleet which is operated by hidden human contractors known within the novels as seers. This study examines how the routing algorithms, safety scores and feedback protocols structuring their fleet produce a condition termed as suspended agency. The responsibility for error is held in permanent technical deferral, assigned neither fully to the human operator nor fully to the automated system. The analysis traces closely to the novel's narrative temporality, its recurring structures of waiting, updating, debugging and recalibrating, arguing that they are not incidental to plot but constitute the formula means by which accountability is postponed often rather than resolved. Focalization and narrative pacing in the novel where the protagonist's evalutive judgment is subsumed by AllOver's scoring architecture, demonstrating that the labour is structurally indispensable to the system's operation even as it remains formally unacknowleged within the corporation's self-representation. The study finds that automation in *Wrong Way* functions not as the replacement of human judgment but as its continual, unacknowledged retention under conditions designed to prevent that judgement from ever being formally recognized. Suspended agency thus emerges as the organizing principle of the novel's critique, the mechanism by which AllOver extracts labour from its seers while permanently deferring the question of where responsibility for that labour's consequences ultimately lies.

Computational Narratology:
How AI Reshapes Narrative Structures and Reader Participation

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Artificial intelligence has moved from being an instrument of composition to a participant in it. Within the digital humanities, large language models now produce narratives that are structurally coherent, tonally consistent, and, on the surface, difficult to separate from human writing. Whether such fluency amounts to creativity remains contested. Where some scholars credit these systems with genuine structural inventiveness, others find their output thin in emotional nuance, weak in the slow work of character development, and largely indifferent to symbolic depth. This paper enters that debate through narratology rather than through claims about machine intelligence. It asks what actually changes in a story when an algorithm helps write it and another algorithm decides who reads it: how plot is sequenced, how character is built, how a reader is positioned and held. Drawing on qualitative textual analysis of AI-generated fiction alongside reader-response data, the study traces the emerging grammar of human-machine co-authorship and the forms of interpretation and emotional resonance it makes possible. The discussion then turns to authorship itself, and to the question of whether algorithmic storytelling widens access to narrative creation or quietly thins out human intention within it. The findings suggest that AI does not merely imitate established storytelling patterns. It generates alternative narrative logics, new orders of causality, attention, and closure, and with them modes of reading that conventional narratology is not yet equipped to describe.

Panel 17:
Archives, Displacement and the Politics of Cultural Memory

Deconstructing Colonial Discourse: Sustainable Historiography and the 1921 Malabar Rebellion

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Language does far more than just describe reality—it shapes how we remember it. Historical narratives are rarely neutral, especially in times when the past is actively being rewritten to fit modern political ends. Focusing on the 1921 Malabar Rebellion, this paper explores how official state discourses decide whose stories get preserved and whose voices get quieted. Using discourse analysis as a qualitative approach, the study digs into the power dynamics woven into colonial record-keeping, focusing specifically on the reports written by G. R. F. Tottenham, then Under Secretary to the Government of Madras. By unpacking these administrative reports, the paper questions the assumed objectivity of imperial reporting and exposes the political motives behind British narratives. The study aims to highlight the subtle ways in which official discourses weaponize the language to shape collective memory, control public narrative and influence social cohesion.

Echoes of the Displaced: Subverting State Narratives and Constructing Identity in Zana Farallon's *The Bone Sparrow* (2016) and Sulaiman Addonia's *Silence Is My Mother Tongue* (2019)

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This paper explores the intersection of discourse, displacement, and identity construction through a comparative literary analysis of Zana Fraillon's *The Bone Sparrow* and Sulaiman Addonia's *Silence Is My Mother Tongue*. Aligning with the imperatives of empowering the humanities to critique mechanisms of exclusion and foster social equity, this study examines how state-sanctioned discourses in refugee camps enforce institutional marginalization and control. Using the theoretical framework of homo sacer and Giorgio Agamben's concept of the "state of exception," the paper analyses how camp spaces reduce displaced individuals to "bare life," stripping them of political agency while serving state-building narratives that prioritize national security over human rights. Through a qualitative discourse analysis of the novels' narratives, this paper deconstructs the power dynamics embedded in state policies of containment and forced assimilation. It contrasts these repressive systems with the protagonists' forced isolation and subversion of quiet. Storytelling turns into a counter-discourse in *The Bone Sparrow*, reclaiming humanity, memory, and agency in the face of structural brutality. In a similar vein, *Silence Is My Mother Tongue* emphasizes body language and silent resistance as potent linguistic modes that subvert cultural hegemony, state-imposed borders, and patriarchy. Both pieces provide a critical lens to rethink social justice and human-cantered sustainability by emphasizing the lived experiences of underprivileged migrants. In the end, this essay shows how literature is an essential instrument in the social sciences to subvert prevailing state narratives, give voice to underrepresented groups, and support an inclusive conversation about human rights, belonging, and nation-building.

What the Archive Did Not Keep: Testimony, Fabulation, and the Memory of Indenture

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Nation-building under colonialism worked both ways: constructing identity within its borders through state power and erasing it for the racialised subjects sent beyond them. Indentured labourers' historical existence survives mostly as entries in recruitment ledgers and plantation records, which recorded them only as numbers, not as individuals. This paper examines Totaram Sanadhya's *My Twenty-One Years in the Fiji Islands; And, the Story of the Haunted Line* and Gaiutra Bahadur's *Coolie Woman: The Odyssey of Indenture* as two different responses to that effacement. Sanadhya provides a rare first-person account from inside the indentured labour system. Generations later, Bahadur confronts a colonial record that barely registers her great-grandmother at all and reconstructs a life from its silences. Drawing on Miranda Fricker's distinction between testimonial and hermeneutical injustice, along with Boaventura de Sousa Santos's concept of epistemicide, this paper argues that Sanadhya's testimony and Bahadur's archival reconstruction represent two different strategies of resistance to the same colonial act of exclusion. Sanadhya's narrative reclaims a voice that survived despite being silenced, while Bahadur is reconstructing a voice that the official record never allowed to exist in the first place. Reading *Coolie Woman* through Saidiya Hartman's idea of critical fabulation, this paper explores the literary and archival recovery as a counter-narrative against the racial prejudice embedded in the colonial record itself.

Who Gets Archived? Digitalization, Linguistic Inequity, and the Making of National Memory

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Digitalization is routinely described as preservation, but every archive begins as an act of selection. India's digital humanities infrastructure has expanded rapidly over the past decade through national digital libraries, manuscript missions, institutional repositories, and large language corpora, and it now determines much of what students, researchers, and policymakers can actually reach. That expansion has been uneven. English and a handful of well-resourced languages dominate machine-readable collections, while oral traditions, folk performance, regional scripts, and the literatures of smaller linguistic communities remain largely outside the searchable record. This paper argues that the asymmetry is not simply a technical backlog awaiting further funding, but a discourse with consequences for national memory. Metadata schemas decide what a text is said to be about. Optical character recognition decides which scripts can be searched at all. Interface design decides what a reader can plausibly find. Taken together, these apparently administrative choices amount to a quiet form of canon formation, carried out without the public debate that accompanied the making of the print canon. Using critical discourse analysis, the study examines the descriptive vocabularies, classification categories, and search architectures of selected Indian digital repositories, reading them as texts that make claims about cultural value rather than as neutral containers for it. The paper closes by arguing for a shift from a custodial model of digitization, in which institutions preserve communities' materials on their behalf, to a participatory model in which communities describe their own holdings in their own categories. Such a shift offers a more equitable and, in the longer term, a more durable foundation for the digital humanities in India.

Counter-Archiving the Nation: An Exploration of Digital Feminist Zines as Third Spaces for South Asian Feminist Discourse

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In South Asia, traditional print publishing and official public archives have historically been gatekept by caste, class, heteronormativity, and state regulation. In response to these structural barriers, contemporary feminist and queer creators have turned to digital zines, such as The Gaysi Zine, The Third Eye, and independent digital collectives, as agile, decentralized platforms for cultural production and political resistance. This paper examines how South Asian digital zines operate as "counter-archives" that dismantle dominant state discourses and construct alternative, inclusive subaltern publics. Bridging Digital Humanities and Gender Studies, this study employs Multimodal Discourse Analysis (Gunther Kress & Theo van Leeuwen) alongside Feminist Counter-Archival Theory (Ann Cvetkovich, Kate Eichhorn). By systematically analyzing a curated sample of digital zines, the paper explores the dynamic interplay between visual art, typography, personal essays, and digital formatting. It demonstrates how these multimodal elements articulate complex experiences of bodily autonomy, cross-border solidarity, and marginalization that are frequently excluded from mainstream postcolonial nation-building discourses. The analysis reveals that digital zines function as affective archives that record living histories of resistance, transforming ephemeral digital interactions into lasting sites of feminist knowledge production. Ultimately, this presentation argues that the digitization of subaltern literary expression does not merely preserve alternative narratives; it actively drives cultural transformation and reframes nation-building by expanding who can participate in the democratic discourse of sustainability, equity, and social justice.

Panel 18:
Affect, Trauma and the Narrative Experience of Loss

From Isolation to Belonging: Constructing Identity and Community in Jacqueline Harpman's *I Who Have Never Known Men*

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Jacqueline Harpman's *I Who Have Never Known Men*, originally published in French in 1995, is set in a post-apocalyptic world where a young girl grows up in a bunker alongside thirty-nine other women, unaware of why they are there or what lies beyond their confined existence. This existence is disrupted when a sudden alarm causes their keepers to abandon the bunker, leaving the women to take control of their own lives for the first time in years. Having no knowledge of the world beyond the enclosure and little understanding of the social structures that shaped the older women's lives, the narrator develops her sense of self in an environment defined by isolation, uncertainty, and limited human contact. When the women eventually escape, they encounter a world in which the structures of society have seemingly disappeared, leaving them to determine how they will live together and what it means to belong. This paper explores the move from isolation to belonging and the construction of identity and community when there is no established social order. It explores the development of the narrator's understanding of herself in her relationships with other people and the problems in trying to belong to a community of people separated by differences in age, memory, experience, and knowledge. The paper argues that the novel does not depict identity and community as static or inherited states but as interactive processes of memory, dependence, and belonging.

The Brain, the Body, and the Narrative Self: A Neurocognitive Approach to Trauma, Memory, and Identity Reconstruction in Ocean Vuong's *On Earth We're Briefly Gorgeous* (2019)

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Contemporary trauma studies progressively recognise trauma not merely as a psychological disruption but as an embodied and neurocognitive phenomenon that reshapes memory, perception, and selfhood. This article examines Ocean Vuong's *On Earth We're Briefly Gorgeous* (2019) through a neurocognitive and neurohumanistic framework to explore the complex relationship between trauma, memory, and identity reconstruction. The study addresses the research gap in existing literary trauma scholarship, which often focuses on representation, testimony, and cultural memory while paying limited attention to the cognitive and embodied mechanisms through which traumatic experiences are processed and transformed into narratives of healing. The purpose of the study is to analyse how Vuong's novel portrays fragmented memories, bodily vulnerability, and storytelling as processes of reconstructing the traumatic self. Employing qualitative textual analysis, the study integrates perspectives from literary trauma theory, cognitive neuroscience, and narrative studies. The theoretical framework draws upon Cathy Caruth's trauma theory, Judith Herman's trauma recovery model, Paul Ricoeur's concept of narrative identity, Antonio Damasio's theory of embodied self, and contemporary theories of neuroplasticity. The study contributes to the burgeoning discourse of Neurohumanities by demonstrating how literary narratives illuminate the cognitive, emotional, and embodied dimensions of trauma. It argues that storytelling operates as a neurocognitive process through which fragmented experiences are reorganised, memories are reinterpreted, and renewed possibilities of identity formation emerge.

The Multiple Dimensions of Loss: A Critical Analysis of Gender and Emotion in Chimamanda Adichie's *Notes on Grief* and C.S. Lewis's *A Grief Observed*

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The concept of the gendered self within autobiographies and memoirs is dynamic rather than static, undergoing continual re-evaluation throughout its creation, particularly with the "other." Memoirs serve as vehicles for authors to reflect upon their emotions and experiences from the past, which are invariably influenced by gender and socialisation patterns. This study contextualises two notable memoirs: *Notes on Grief* by Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie and *A Grief Observed* by C.S. Lewis, to analyse how the authors' gender is represented and how it intertwines with their emotional expressions as they employ memoirs as mediums for mourning and self-articulation. In this proposed study, four grieving patterns—intuitive, instrumental, blended, and dissonant—identified by Terry L. Martin and Kenneth J. Doka in Men Don't Cry, Women Do: Transcending Gender Stereotypes of Grief—are assessed to illustrate their influence on, yet not their determination by, gender. A key investigative point is the interplay between gender roles and emotional expression in Adichie and Lewis, highlighting the gender stereotypes of grief that each author navigates, whether by embracing or challenging them. The analysis reveals that both authors conform to prevailing gender stereotypes of grief in many instances while also exhibiting resistance in others. This signals the complex and multifaceted nature of bereavement, which often transcends established gender and social boundaries, thus contesting prescriptive notions regarding the appropriate expression of loss.

The Psychology of "What if"-Counterfactual theory in *The Midnight Library* (2020)

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The Midnight Library (2020) by Matt Haig explores consequences of Counterfactual thinking. It inspect the theory of Counterfactual through the protagonist Nora Seed, a 35 year old woman whose life is subjugated in regret and loneliness, who is given the experience other lives she could have lived, based on the choices she did not make. This paper examines the effects of persistent "What If "thoughts on human emotions, identity and decision-making based on counterfactual theory. Counterfactual theory is a psychological outcomes to past events by asking questions like "What if", "If only". These imagined alternatives are called counterfactual because they are contrary to what actually happened. It often lead to regret,remorse,self blame and unreasonable expectations. Nora's repeated questioning of hypothetical scenario demonstrates discontent, but instead highlight the intricacies and uncertainties of human existence. Haig does not present alternative lives as panaceas but rather shows that meaning is not located in ideal life but in imperfection and the here and now. The paper also emphasises how the novel challenges the illusion that happiness is a function of different choices, highlighting instead the psychological importance of self-compassion and cognitive reframing.This research contributes to the interdisciplinary dialogue about mental well being, identity construction and modern literature by providing a synthesis of literary analysis and psychological theory, demonstrating how the Midnight Library reconfigures the function of what if thinking from one of regret to one of self improvement and emotional recovery.

"This is the same for every family!": Hostile Household, and the Refusal of Clinical Containment in *Bhoothakaalam* (2022)

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In the conventional gaze, the domestic sphere is often characterised as a comforting space, and the awareness of mental health medications among members of a community often signals progress and maturity. However, a distinguishing feature of the Horror genre is its ability to make the familiar into grotesque and the innocent into the wicked. In the Malayalam horror film *Bhoothakaalam* (2022), the presence of the supernatural deconstructs the accepted notions about domesticity and mental health. The film's spectral haunting functions not as a supernatural intrusion, but as the objective correlative of the family's transmitted neglect, fear of abandonment, and unspoken grief. This paper proposes an affective reading of Bhoothakaalam, drawing on Teresa Brennan's theory of the "transmission of affect" alongside Eve Sedgwick's frameworks of "affective scripts" and "reparative reading." Using close textual analysis, this paper examines how affects, such as anxiety, grief, or hostility, are not contained within the individual consciousness but are physically transmitted across bodies and environments. The characters in the film, a mother and her son, are trapped between the desire to escape their dependence on each other and the precarious economic conditions. The frustration of leading such a life, coupled with patriarchal and societal pressures, generates a suffocating affective atmosphere. Any form of therapy and medical prescriptions, therefore, are only measures of containment and not healing because they are oblivious of the structural and societal problems the characters face.

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Panel 19:
Agency, Labour and Behavioural Change for Sustainable Futures

Beyond Dependency: Weaver Agency and Coping Strategies in the Banarasi Handloom Saree Industry

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The Banarasi handloom saree industry is widely understood through the multiple, interlocking conditions that constrain it, shaping weavers' everyday reality well beyond any single dimension of hardship. This paper turns the analytical lens in a different direction, examining not how weavers are constrained, but how they act within that constraint. Moving beyond a dependency framing, it draws on Norman Long's actor oriented approach in development sociology, alongside a livelihoods based typology of coping strategies, to examine the agency and coping mechanisms of handloom weavers, allied workers, and women workers across four weaving clusters in Varanasi. Based on in depth interviews and focus group discussions analysed thematically, the study identifies strategies at the individual, household, and attempted collective level, including occupational and product diversification, a calculated refusal of unfamiliar digital market channels, fragile solidarity that sustains survival but not collective bargaining, the quiet renegotiation of household decision making by women, and migration weighed as a tested rather than an assumed strategy. The paper argues that behaviour often read from outside as passivity is better understood as situated calculation. Repositioning weavers as knowledgeable actors negotiating a constrained field offers an agency centred counterpoint to dependency based explanations of artisanal precarity, and points to interventions that build on the coping capacities weavers already exercise.

From Servant Leadership to Sustainable HRM: Examining the Mediating Role of Employee Empowerment and Engagement

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Organizations now-a-day are looking forward to achieving long-term sustainability while creating workplaces where employees feel involved, and supported. In such an evolving environment, leadership plays a crucial role in shaping how employees experience their work and perform towards organizational goals. With its focus on serving employees, servant leadership understands their needs, supports growth, and encourages participation and offers a people-oriented approach to leadership. This study explores how servant leadership can confer to Sustainable Human Resource Management through employee empowerment and engagement. The study suggests that when leaders trust their employees, give them preference, involve them in policy-making, and provide chances for development, employees feel empowered and valued. This empowerment can reinforce their eagerness towards work, resulting in higher employee engagement. As a result, engaged and empowered employees can participate in sustainable HR practices by encouraging employee development, well-being, retention, participation, and responsible workplace practices. Quantitative research methodology is used to analyse this research. Questionnaire method is used to understand employees' perceptions of servant leadership, empowerment, engagement, and sustainable HR practices. The study emphasises that sustainable HRM is not only about policies and organizational outcomes but also about how people are valued, encouraged, and empowered at work. By collaborating servant leadership with employee empowerment and engagement, the study suggests an employee-centred perspective on building inclusive, participative, and sustainable workplaces. The findings are expected to offer an understanding for HR professionals and organizational leaders looking forward to building workplaces that encourage and support the organizational sustainability and permanent well-being and development of employees.

Rethinking Sustainable Nation-Building through Behavioural and Cultural Changes

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Sustainable nation-building is often discussed in terms of economic development and technological innovation, yet enduring progress ultimately depends on people, their values, choices, and everyday practices. Behavioral and cultural change forms the foundation of this transformation, shaping how individuals engage with society, the environment, and one another. This paper explores how the humanities provide critical insights into understanding and encouraging such change by fostering empathy, ethical responsibility, cultural awareness, and civic consciousness. It argues that sustainable development cannot be achieved through policy alone; it requires a shift in collective attitudes and lived practices. By foregrounding the human dimension of sustainability, the paper highlights the importance of integrating cultural understanding with behavioural transformation to build inclusive, resilient, and socially responsible communities. Such an approach offers a meaningful pathway towards a more sustainable and equitable future.

Decision-Making in the Face of Uncertainty:
Exploring Psychological Hardiness and Intolerance of Uncertainty

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Decision-making often takes place under conditions of limited information, ambiguity, discrepancies, and unpredictability, making individuals' responses to uncertainty an important psychological consideration. In such circumstances, the ability to navigate uncertainty while evaluating possible courses of action becomes particularly relevant to adaptive and reflective decision-making. Intolerance of uncertainty may make ambiguous situations more difficult to navigate and has been associated with avoidant and less rational decision-making styles. Although existing research has established a relationship between intolerance of uncertainty and decision-making styles, the potential role of psychological hardiness in shaping this relationship remains insufficiently explored. The present paper proposes a conceptual model examining the potential moderating role of psychological hardiness in the relationship between intolerance of uncertainty and decision-making styles. The model draws upon the intolerance of uncertainty model, Kobasa's theory of psychological hardiness, and the General Decision-Making Style framework. Relevant theoretical and empirical literature was examined to identify the conceptual relationships among the three constructs and inform the development of the proposed model. The literature indicates that intolerance of uncertainty may be associated with less adaptive decision-making tendencies, while psychological hardiness, characterized by commitment, control, and challenge, may influence how individuals respond to uncertain and complex situations. The proposed model integrates these relationships to offer a psychological perspective on decision-making under uncertainty, with implications for reflective decision-making, critical thinking, reflexivity, and behavioral change. Future empirical research can test the proposed relationships across diverse contexts.

Panel 20:
Interdisciplinary Approaches to Nation-Building

Translating Environmental Justice: Bio-semiotics, Policy, and Governance in Nation-Building

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Environmental justice frameworks in contemporary policy discourse remain conceptually anchored in Euro-American legal traditions. Their transposition into multilingual, postcolonial states renders translation a site of bio-semiotic negotiation rather than neutral linguistic transfer, one in which the sign-systems through which land, water, and non-human life communicate meaning must be rendered legible to state institutions without conceptual flattening. This paper theorizes bio-semiotic translation, the translation of meaning generated within and between human and non-human sign-systems, as a critical, under examined instrument of environmental governance. Drawing on the Chambal rumal, an embroidered narrative tradition encoding land, water, and kinship through visual and material sign-systems, the paper identifies an ontological gap underlying apparent lexical equivalence when such bio-semiotic knowledge is rendered into administrative idiom. This mistranslation, largely invisible within governance structures, generates policies that perform inclusivity while structurally reproducing the marginalization of communities most exposed to ecological precarity. Situating the analysis within Translation Studies, bio-semiotics, and postcolonial theory, the paper examines translations dual valence: as a mechanism of state appropriation that selectively renders non-human and material sign-systems legible for extractive legitimization, and as an instrument of justice when undertaken with fidelity to source sign-systems. It proposes a framework for biosemiotically-attentive translation practice and more important policymaking, advocating the integration of translators and community knowledge-holders at the drafting stage of environmental legislation. The paper explores how environmental justice, biosemiotically conceived, is inseparable from questions of epistemic authorization, whose sign-systems are rendered translatable, and thus governable, within the nation-building project.

Role of Humanities and Social Sciences in Nation Building

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Humanities and Social Sciences play a vital role in shaping the intellectual, ethical, cultural, and social foundations of a nation. While economic growth, scientific advancement, and technological innovation are essential for national development, sustainable nation building also requires an understanding of human values, social relationships, cultural diversity, historical consciousness, and democratic participation. This paper explores the transformative role of Humanities and Social Sciences in nation building, with particular emphasis on cultural identity, social justice, democratic values, inclusive development, and sustainability. It argues that a strong and progressive nation cannot be built solely through material and technological advancement; it must also invest in human dignity, ethical values, cultural understanding, and social well-being. Strengthening Humanities and Social Sciences is therefore essential for creating a resilient, inclusive, democratic, and sustainable society. Disciplines such as history, literature, philosophy, sociology, political science, economics, psychology, education, geography, and anthropology provide critical perspectives for understanding society and addressing complex contemporary challenges. In the contemporary context, the role of Humanities and Social Sciences has become even more significant in addressing challenges such as social inequality, gender discrimination, communal tensions, environmental degradation, migration, digital transformation, artificial intelligence, and cultural change.

Reimagining Corporate Governance in Viksit Bharat: Lessons from Kautilya's *Arthashastra* for ESG, Accountability and Responsible Capitalism

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The vision of Viksit Bharat (Developed India) requires robust corporate governance frameworks that promote ethical business conduct, accountability, transparency, and sustainable economic growth. Contemporary corporate scandals have exposed persistent governance failures, including financial misconduct, conflicts of interest, inadequate board oversight, and weak accountability mechanisms, strengthening the need for effective Environmental, Social, and Governance (ESG) practices. Interestingly, several of these concerns find resonance in Kautilya's *Arthashastra*, an ancient Indian treatise on governance, economics, and administration. Kautilya recognised the risks associated with the misuse of entrusted authority and advocated systematic audits, continuous supervision, accountability, ethical leadership, and stringent penalties for corruption. This paper examines the relevance of Kautilya's governance principles to contemporary corporate governance and India's evolving ESG framework through a doctrinal and comparative analysis. It explores the convergence between principles of accountability, transparency, fiduciary responsibility, stakeholder welfare, and ethical administration reflected in the Arthashastra and modern corporate governance norms under the Companies Act, 2013, SEBI regulations, and global ESG standards. The paper argues that integrating indigenous governance wisdom with modern legal and regulatory mechanisms can contribute to a distinctive Indian model of responsible capitalism. Such an approach can strengthen corporate accountability, stakeholder trust, ethical business practices, and sustainable development, thereby supporting the broader objectives of Viksit Bharat. The study concludes that Kautilya's insights remain valuable normative foundations for reimagining corporate governance in the twenty-first century.

Between the Radio and the Road: A Critical Discourse Analysis of Development and Nation-Building in *Fire in the Mountains*

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Nation-building is often defined through narratives of development, technological progress, and inclusive governance. However, the lived experiences of marginalized communities reveal the unequal distribution of these promises. Ajitpal Singh's *Fire in the Mountains* (2021) presents this issue through the story of Chandra, a woman living in the remote Himalayan region of Uttarakhand, whose daily struggles reveal the gap between state-led narratives of progress and rural realities. In the film, radio broadcasts the celebration of national achievements, infrastructural development, and technological advancement while the visual narrative portrays absence of roads, inadequate healthcare, gendered labour, and social exclusion. This paper examines the film through Critical Discourse Analysis, focusing on Michel Foucault's concept of discourse and power/knowledge and Norman Fairclough's discourse theory, to examine how the film constructs and challenges the discourse of development and nation-building. It also draws upon Amartya Sen's Capability Approach, which views development as the expansion of people's freedoms and access to opportunities rather than mere economic growth. The paper argues that the recurring radio announcements project an image of a progressive nation, while Chandra's life exposes the inequalities hidden beneath this developmental rhetoric. The paper demonstrates that sustainable nation-building extends beyond economic or technological achievements to include social justice and equitable access to public resources. The study contributes to contemporary discussions in humanities by portraying how cinema serves as a critical site for interrogating dominant developmental discourses and reimagining more inclusive and sustainable visions of the nation.

Panel 21:
Ecological Belonging and Literary Landscapes

Flowing Identity: Rivers and the Transformation of Karna in the *Mahabharata*

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Karna is one of the most complex figures in the Mahabharata. His identity is never completely fixed. Born as Kunti's son and abandoned as an infant, he is raised by Adhiratha and Radha and grows up as a Suta. He later becomes king of Anga and Duryodhana's closest ally. Even after learning the truth of his birth, he does not accept it as his only identity. His life is shaped by the pull between birth, upbringing, status, and choice. This paper looks closely at the recurring presence of rivers in Karna's story. It argues that water is not just a symbol of change. It is the space through which his identity is displaced, questioned, and finally recognized. Through close textual reading of the critical-edition Mahabharata, the paper traces three riverine episodes: the infant Karna's passage through several rivers to Adhiratha's household, which separates him from his biological lineage and relocates him within a different social world; Kunti's revelation of his birth on the banks of the Ganga before the war, which he refuses to let overwrite the identity he has built; and the Ganga's reappearance after his death, when his true kinship with the Pandavas is finally acknowledged through water rites. Reading these moments together, the paper finds that the river's fluidity consistently contrasts with the rigid social identities imposed on Karna, positioning water as the medium through which the epic stages the continual making and remaking of social identity.

Who Owns the Grassland? Ecological Citizenship, Environmental Justice and the Politics of Belonging in Jiang Rong's *Wolf Totem*

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Jiang Rong's *Wolf Totem* presents the Mongolian grassland as a contested ecological and cultural space where community, nature, power, and belonging intersect. Moving beyond conventional ecocritical readings that primarily scrutinize anthropocentrism and environmental degradation, this paper approaches the novel through the concept of ecological citizenship to examine who possesses the authority to define, manage, interpret, and speak for the environment. It argues that environmental justice in the novel is inseparable from the politics of belonging, particularly in determining whose ecological knowledge, cultural practices, and relationships with the non-human world are recognized as legitimate. The paper demonstrates that the decline of ecological imbalance is not merely a consequence of environmental degradation but also a conflict over environmental authority and cultural identity. The pastoral communities are represented as historically connected to the grassland, while state-driven interventions seek to reshape the landscape according to political, economic, and developmental priorities. This conflict reveals that ecological consequences are unevenly experienced and that environmental governance is closely connected to structures of power. The paper further examines how the marginalization of local ecological knowledge complicates the idea of environmental justice. It raises a fundamental question: how can communities historically connected to landscape be excluded from determining its ecological future? By foregrounding ecological citizenship, the paper concludes that sustainable environmental governance requires recognition of diverse ecological knowledge systems and meaningful participation in environmental decision-making. Wolf Totem thus becomes a literary site for reimagining sustainability through ecological rights, cultural belonging, social justice, and environmental accountability.

Sprung Grief: Solastalgia and the Ecological Body in the Poetry of Gerard Manley Hopkins

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Solastalgia, Glenn Albrecht's term for the psychic distress produced by environmental change experienced in place, is a diagnostic vocabulary that emerged only in 2005. Gerard Manley Hopkins's poetry, written a century earlier amid the ecological upheavals of Victorian industrialisation, arguably stages this affective condition long before medicine or environmental psychology named it. Through the reading of Hopkins's *Binsey Poplars*, *God's Grandeur*, *Inversnaid,* and *The Sea and the Skylark*, this paper proposes that Hopkins's metrical innovation "sprung rhythm", functions as a formal correlative of environmental grief. Here, the composition is analysed through the strain, compression, and self-interruption of his lines, which enact the perceptual disruption his speakers describe. The analysis is structured around four affective registers: direct loss, habituated numbness, anticipatory dread, and sensory disruption. The essay situates this reading within an emerging body of scholarship (Parham's Green Man Hopkins, recent work on Hopkins's "ecological perception") while extending it toward the health humanities, a field that has typically treated literary form as illustrative of affective experience. Further, this paper repositions Hopkins's prosody as evidentiary, demonstrating that his metrical strain functions as evidence of ecological grief. The paper's broader claim is that nineteenth-century nature poetry constitutes an underused archive for the medical and psychological humanities.

Uneven Vulnerabilities on the Coast: Reading Environmental Injustice through Odia Cinema

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While climate action and sustainability have gained increasing attention, the impacts of environmental change remain deeply uneven, particularly among marginalised communities. This paper examines the ecological injustice experienced by coastal communities in Odisha through an ecocritical analysis of two Odia films, *Kalira Atita* (2020) and *Kokoli* (2021). Through close textual reading and thematic analysis of the two films, the paper studies how ecological disruption affects livelihoods, landscapes, memory and psychological well-being, while also revealing the deep dependence of coastal communities on the sea. The analysis reveals how vulnerability is shaped by unequal access to resources, socio-economic conditions, and the uneven distribution of environmental risks and responsibilities. It also draws attention to whose lives and livelihoods are most exposed to ecological disruption and whose experiences remain less visible in dominant discussions of climate resilience. The paper further highlights how the lack of social equity limits the resources, opportunities and agency available to marginalized communities to respond to environmental changes. This research positions Odia cinema as an important cultural space for articulating marginalised environmental experiences and contributes to broader discussions of environmental justice, sustainability and the need for more inclusive and socially grounded understandings of environmental resilience.

Digging for the Ganga: Water Scarcity and Environmental Justice in Sarnath Banerjee's *All Quiet in Vikaspuri*

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Sarnath Banerjee's *All Quiet in Vikaspuri* (2015) is a dystopian future tale about Delhi, wherein a drought-ridden city is marked by the search for the mythical river Ganga, as well as ecological breakdown, and the search for the river reflects the desperate situation that is brought about by the failure of development and lack of natural resources. The present research explores Banerjee's graphic narrative through the prism of hydro-politics, class, and urban marginality with the help of AI-assisted analysis and thematic mapping. The paper argues that the use of visualisation techniques by Banerjee sheds light on the paradoxes in which state-driven development schemes are engaged: on the one hand, such schemes promote ecological revitalisation and, on the other hand, reproduce the social exclusion and segregation of communities. It is through the analysis of the patterns of water shortage and environmental violence that the paper addresses the ethical dimension of the use of computational methods in order to read texts representing ecological trauma and injustices. In general, it can be said that *All Quiet in Vikaspuri* offers an important conceptual framework for thinking about the entanglements between resource politics, myths, and environmental justice in the age of artificial intelligence.

Panel 22:
Health Humanities: Illness, Care and Medical Power

Becoming Bare Life: Biopolitical Control, Cure and Collapse in David B.'s *Epileptic*

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David B.'s graphic memoir, *Epileptic*, sketches the endless fight of the Beauchard family against the disabling illness of Jean-Christophe's epilepsy. In this paper, I examine how the Beauchards' diegetic story about medical spaces, medications, and macrobiotic communes situates their struggle against a controlled societal machinery of normativity, ability, and productivity. This paper reads *Epileptic* as a relentless critique of a world that relies on binary hierarchies of Self and the Other by situating Jean-Christophe within the Foucauldian nexus of power, surveillance, and institutional discipline to expose the mechanisms through which illness becomes a site of regulation, exclusion, and trauma. The clinical institutions in the text are studied as a biopolitical apparatus that disciplines the diseased body through medical intervention, reducing the patient to Agamben's "bare life" and suspending him between states of vegetative existence and disposability. The paper also extends the reading of curative crisis to caregivers, where Deleuze and Guattari's mechanics of "becoming" problematise the discourses of care by appropriating tragic epithets that destabilise familial dynamics, producing emotional contagion, fear, and internalised forms of identity exclusion. By focusing on the intersecting narratives of cure, care, and control to critique the violence embedded within medical and social systems, this paper demonstrates how quotidian violence against bodies is not read as an isolated personal tragedy but as a political and existential crisis inextricably tied to the governance of bodies and lives.

Traditional Medicine and Healing Practices in the Dhodia Tribe

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Dhodia, a Scheduled Tribe residing in South Gujarat and some parts of Maharashtra follows a certain traditional medicinal, curing and healing practices for years. It is a mixture of herbal/medicinal plants and its remedies and spiritual healing. This paper focuses on Traditional healers such as Bhagats/Bhuvas diagnose and treat diseases using mantras, or local plants while Dayan assists in childbirth. There is less systematic research of those herbal plants, the preparation method, doses, and disease-specific application used in Dhodia tribe. The paper aims to highlight the use of herbal and spiritual methods of Dhodia tribe emphasizing on the roles of Traditional healers, the interconnectedness of spiritual healing and medicine, associated beliefs and the need for systematic documentation. Through ethnographic research, and interviews, the study identifies certain medicinal plants used to treat different illnesses and in sustaining the traditional cultural medicinal practice, and the conservation practice. This indigenous knowledge of herbal medicines and practices and the connection with spiritual healing are at the greater risk because of modernization, and greater reliance on biomedical and need to be preserved.

Body, Self, and Mental Health: Probing Minority Stress in *I Am Vidya*

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An individual is not only shaped by one's own sense of being but also by the proximal factors around them. Identity consists of several factors, and society is the most significant one of them. Identity also depends on mental health, and society is a major determinant of it. For gender-diverse or non-conforming individuals, it becomes a constant battleground for situating their identity. Similarly, for transgender individuals, mental health becomes a prominent health hazard because of the social conditions in which trans identities are lived, negotiated, and contested. This paper examines the intersections of body, self, and mental health in the autobiographical narrative *I am Vidya: A Transgender's Journey* (2013) by Living Smile Vidya. Drawing on Ilan H. Meyer's theorization of Minority Stress (2003), the study explores how the pressures associated with non-normative gender expectations shape Vidya's psychological well-being. This paper explores the ways in which familial rejection, social stigma, discrimination, humiliation and persistent corrected behaviour produce stress and affect trans individuals' mental well-being within the social structures and everyday interactions that marginalize non-binary people. The paper investigates how trans individuals' experiences with the normative setting affect their mental health. The paper contributes to broader conversations within Health Humanities about identity, social exclusion, and psychological well-being.

Panel 23:
Writing Against the Grain:
Gender, Identity, and Resistance in Contemporary Narratives

Negotiating Culture, Sustainability, and Female Resistance in Contemporary Indian Women's Fiction

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The vision of Viksit Bharat demands looking at a developed India where social sustainability and Indigenous knowledge traditions are prioritized. Under the sub-theme Language, Culture, and Indigenous Heritage and Sustainable Future, this paper discusses how cultural heritage is transmitted within gendered environments. Development discussions often construct heritage through monuments and state traditions, leaving a critical research gap: unthinking heritage preservation conceals patriarchal suppression enforced on female bodies. Addressing this disparity, this study investigates 1990s Indian English domestic novels by Shashi Deshpande and Anita Desai, examining how traditional idioms and domestic rituals serve as instruments of patriarchal surveillance while women navigate freedom without abandoning cultural heritage. Adopting a qualitative, multidisciplinary methodology, this research integrates literary analysis, postcolonial feminist theory, and cultural materialism. Specifically, critical discourse analysis examines dialogue, internal monologues, and thematic motifs, treating language as an ideological domain where domestic silence and patriarchal hierarchies meet. Furthermore, Sen's Capability Approach evaluates female agency against institutionalized cultural barriers. Preliminary findings indicate female protagonists do not favor Western hyper-individualism but engage in resistance to internally patriarchal hegemony. This paper argues that true socio-cultural sustainability, a vital pillar of Viksit Bharat, is unattainable if traditions remain closed-minded and unequal. It concludes with key policy implications for cultural governance and education by offering an indigenous model of gender resistance, advocating that domestic equality must be integrated into national development to promote resilient, inclusive communities.

Writing the Self, Contesting the Nation: Transgender Autobiography as Counter-Discourse to Hegemonic National Identity in India

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The postcolonial Indian nation-state has consolidated its identity through normative regimes of gender and sexuality, producing a majoritarian citizen-subject against which transgender lives remain marginal, if not illegible, within official narratives of belonging. This paper argues that transgender autobiography constitutes a significant counter-discourse to this hegemonic construction, transforming embodied, first-person testimony into an act of political and epistemic intervention. The study pursues three objectives: to examine how transgender life narratives destabilize dominant nationalist constructions of gender and citizenship; to interrogate the discursive strategies through which such narratives assert political and social legitimacy; and to situate transgender autobiography within broader scholarly debates on social equity and inclusive nation-building. Methodologically, the paper employs qualitative discourse analysis, drawing on Michel Foucault's theorization of power/knowledge and Ken Plummer's framework of "sexual storytelling" as a mode of social action. Using a comparative, text-based design, the study offers a close thematic reading of select published Indian transgender autobiographies, attending to recurrent motifs of familial rejection, ritual kinship within hijra communities, encounters with medico-legal institutions, and negotiations of citizenship, read against the state's assimilationist logic of national identity formation. The analysis suggests these autobiographies function not merely as testimonies of exclusion but as counter-archives that reconstitute alternative frameworks of belonging, kinship, and civic personhood, positioning self-narration as political agency amid incomplete legal and institutional recognition. The paper concludes that transgender autobiography warrants recognition as a central, rather than peripheral, site of inquiry within discourses of Indian nation-building, and that theorizing inclusive nationhood remains incomplete without accounting for the narrative agency of communities historically excluded from its definition.

Visualising Trans Graphic Medicine: Gender, Gatekeeping, and Gazing in Emma Grove's *The Third Person*

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In LGBTQIA+ storytelling, transgender narratives are under and misrepresented. Transgender people's lives are plural and intersectional, and are often complicated by trauma and abuse faced because of the presentation of gender dysphoria. Through a verbo-visual exposition of *The Third Person*, this paper investigates how the transgender person is gatekept from transitional possibilities at the hand of the uneven standards of the biomedical system. Unlike mainstream trans memoirs, *The Third Person* employs a simplistic art style to present the perspective of the intersectional trans patient, a subject that has been long marginalized and misrepresented. The use of the graphic memoir medium is a powerful tool to delineate the lived experiences of trans people as they navigate a system that fails their aspirations with themselves. The questioning and doubt that marks the medical life of Emma distances her from the system, and by extension herself. In this line, this paper will attempt to analyze how Grove employs the graphic technique to visualize her dissociation and marginalization. It will close-read the memoir to evaluate trans lived experience. In doing so, this paper deals with the overlooked aspect of the role of intra-community hierarchies and gatekeeping in complicating trans lives, and problematises the gaze of a transgender therapist. Conclusively, this paper aims to contribute to the body of work called trans graphic medicine and positions *The Third Person* as an essential counter-narrative.

Her Story, Her Power: Reclaiming Female Agency in *Bulbbul* and *Stree* through Intersectional Feminist Perspectives

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Intersectionality and feminism work together to examine how different aspects of a woman's identity, including gender, class, caste, social status, tradition, and cultural expectations, interact to shape experiences of oppression, discrimination, and resistance. This study examines *Bulbbul* (2020) and *Stree* (2018) as contemporary Indian films which challenge traditional representations of women, patriarchy, and female agency in society. Building on the theory of intersectionality (Crenshaw) and a feminist lens (Bell hooks, Patricia Hill Collins, Judith Butler, Sara Ahmed, Chandra Talpade Mohanty, and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak), this study explores how gender intersects with other identities such as class, caste, social status, tradition, and cultural expectations to frame experiences of oppression and resistance for women. While Bulbbul transforms a victimized woman into an instrument of supernatural retribution, Stree uses horror and satire to critique gendered double standards and societal hypocrisy. A comparative analysis examines how class, caste, and social status shape gendered experiences in both films. *Bulbbul* portrays patriarchal hierarchies through wealth, family, marriage, and social position, while *Stree* highlights gendered restrictions within a community and the unequal expectations placed on men and women. Both films reveal how gender hierarchies regulate women's mobility, sexuality, reputation, and agency, while their differences reflect distinct forms of oppression and resistance. They function as influential cultural texts for modern audiences in North India, demonstrating how contemporary Indian cinema can challenge patriarchal structures while exposing the intersections between gender and broader social hierarchies.

Understanding Queer Identity Formation Through *Sex Education*: A Psychological Analysis

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Sexual Identity development or formation remains a complex process for most individuals who belong to the queer community. It includes confusion, social and personal other challenges before it leads to self-acceptance and identity pride. This study examines how this identity is formed in Netflix's series *Sex Education* through Vivienne Cass's Model of Sexual Identity Development. The series showcases how queer identity is a gradual, complex, and confusing process shaped by society, family, relationships, peers, and, last but not least, a person's internal experiences. Focusing on the characters Eric and Adam, this study asks: How does *Sex Education* represent the formation of queer identity? And how do their relationships and social environments lead them to identity acceptance? In the series, Eric is shown as someone with a comparatively developed understanding of his sexuality, and his experiences show the continuing importance of social recognition and acceptance. On the contrary, Adam experiences great confusion, difficulty and uncertainty in accepting his sexuality, which makes his journey particularly relevant to the theory. The study proclaims that the series showcases queer identity as not an instant discovery but rather an evolving process influenced by an individual's experiences and relationship with self as well as with society as a whole. Using Cass's six-stage model, the analysis aims to demonstrate how Eric and Adam represent different experiences of identity development while also focusing on the importance of supportive relationships in achieving acceptance

Panel 24:
Interdisciplinary Inquiries into Health and Illness

Maternal Prenatal Emotional Experience and Child Neurodevelopmental Difficulties: A Retrospective Case Study

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The prenatal period is a critical stage of neurological development. Maternal psychological and biological conditions during pregnancy may influence the intrauterine environment. This retrospective case study explores maternal emotional experiences during pregnancy in relation to developmental difficulties observed in a child. The case involved a three-year-old male child with delayed speech, hyperactivity, behavioral difficulties, poor balance, difficulty in jumping and climbing, limited communication of basic needs, fear of loud sounds, and reduced social interaction. Medical history included fever with seizure at approximately two years of age and a brain cyst reported on MRI. Pregnancy history included reduced amniotic fluid and maternal thyroid disturbance. A semi-structured in-depth interview was conducted with the mother. The dominant emotional theme was persistent insecurity related to the possible loss of her grandmother, who was an important emotional and financial support for the family. The mother expressed, “If grandmother dies, how will the family survive?” and “We are alone; we have to manage everything ourselves.” Her core experience involved fear of losing support, uncertainty about the future, burden of responsibility, difficulty balancing her maternal and marital families, and inability to express these concerns because she felt nobody would understand. Qualitative analysis identified anticipatory anxiety, fear of loss of support, insecurity, perceived responsibility, emotional suppression, and helplessness as recurring themes. The case highlights the importance of considering maternal prenatal psychological experiences together with biological, medical, and postnatal factors in child development. It does not establish causation but provides an exploratory psychosomatic perspective for further research.

Narrating Health and Illness:
Literature as a Tool for Social Transformation

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Health and illness are not merely biological or medical experiences; they are also shaped by social, cultural, and emotional contexts. Literature provides an important space for representing these dimensions of human experience and questioning dominant understandings of health and illness. This paper examines the role of literary narratives in Health Humanities, focusing on how representations of illness can contribute to empathy, awareness, critical reflection, and social transformation. The study explores how literary texts give voice to experiences of illness, vulnerability, caregiving, disability, and mental health that may remain invisible within conventional medical discourse. Through narrative voice, characterization, embodiment, and interpersonal relationships, literature communicates the lived experience of illness and enables readers to engage with health-related experiences from multiple perspectives. Such narratives can challenge stereotypes and reveal how stigma, social expectations, and cultural attitudes influence the understanding of illness. Drawing on the interdisciplinary approach of Health Humanities, the paper argues that literature can extend conversations about health beyond the clinical setting. By bringing individual experiences into the public and cultural sphere, literary narratives encourage dialogue about care, dignity, inclusion, and social responsibility. They can also challenge established assumptions and create space for marginalized voices. The paper proposes that literature can contribute to behavioural and cultural change by fostering empathy and inclusive understandings of health and illness. Thus, Health Humanities highlights literature as a valuable resource for developing compassionate and socially responsive approaches to human health and experience.

From *Manichitrathazhu* to *Bhool Bhulaiyaa*: Bollywoodisation and the Representation of Mental Illness in Indian Cinema

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Cinema plays a significant role in constructing and disseminating meanings about mental illness, influencing the ways in which psychological conditions and identities are understood by audiences. This paper explores the representation of mental illness and psychological identity in *Manichitrathazhu* (1993) and its Bollywood adaptation *Bhool Bhulaiyaa* (2007) through the character of Avni and her assumed identity as Manjulika. Using primarily the representation theory of Stuart Hall, the paper analyzes the representation of illness, identity, superstition, and scientific reasoning through narratives, characterization, symbolism, and cinematic techniques employed in the films. Instead of focusing on the accuracy with which the two films present dissociative identity disorder (DID), the paper focuses on the way these disorders were reinterpreted in different cultural contexts and adapted into the norms of the target audience. In addition to that, the paper uses the concept of Bollywoodisation to argue how the adaptation changed the way the source material presented the psychological condition and to what extent the modified version of DID resists its original meaning. Although *Manichitrathazhu* depicted the psychological condition in a relatively straightforward manner, *Bhool Bhulaiyaa* used comedy, drama, suspense, and special effects to appeal to a larger audience. Moreover, the representation of Avni's DID and its 'treatment' blurs the boundaries between DID, schizophrenia, and superstitions, and portrays a conflict between unscientific and scientific approaches to mental illness. By analyzing the two films, the paper argues that adaptation is not only a process of recontextualization but also of renegotiation of meaning. Thus, *Bhool Bhulaiyaa* not only adapts the story to the norms of Bollywood cinema but also changes the ways in which the audience perceives the symptoms and the treatment of DID.